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Loudoun County School Board, 2nd Tuesday School Board Meeting, Tuesday, January 13, 2026

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Place Loudoun County Public Schools / School Board meeting (see BoardDocs / LCPS-TV)
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[00:03:47] Good afternoon. I call to order, oh, excuse me, my first day officially in this position. So thank you for your patience. Good afternoon. I call to order this January 13th, 2026 Loudoun County School Board meeting. First off, I want to acknowledge the tragic loss in our school community today, and I want to let the public know that we will recognize this tragedy with a moment of silence at the start of the formal meeting later tonight. We will move on to item number 1.02, remote attendance. I have been notified that Vice Chair Donohue would like to

[00:04:25] remotely participate in tonight's school board meeting. Vice Chair Donohue, please state your location and whether this is a medical or personal matter. Good evening, and thank you, Madam Chair. I am in my dining room in my home, and this is a medical matter. Thank you, Vice Chair Donohue.

[00:04:48] Thank you also for stating your location, and is there anyone else in the home with you at this time? My spouse and children are also at home, but they are not in the room with me. Thank you. This will be Vice Chair Donahue's first remote participation for this calendar year in a school board meeting using a medical exemption.

[00:05:11] Therefore, I will entertain a motion that Vice Chair Donahue's request to participate remotely be granted. Thank you, Mr. Pepper. could i ask you please to speak into the microphone yes i move that

vice chair donahue be allowed to participate in this meeting remotely thank you mr pepper is there a second thank you second dr

[00:05:38] rashid okay it has been properly moved and seconded clerk please open the vote school board members

[00:05:52] please record your vote clerk please close and display the vote the motion passes unanimously with all school school board members who are present and vice chair donahue welcome to the

[00:06:29] meeting let's move on we will need to do our disclosures i will read i will start as a member of the loudon county school board i make the following disclosure to the school board into the general public in connection with the item on tonight's agenda regarding the budget and or health insurance and related benefits and any other discussion that may include or affect benefits for lcps employees specifically as a school board member i am eligible to receive health insurance and related benefits as an lcps employee these benefits however affect thousands

[00:07:07] of employees well in excess of the statutory three employees whose interests may also be affected of which i am included i can and will participate fairly objectively and in the public interest this disclosure will be reflected in the public records of the clerk of the school board for five years. Vice Chair Donahue. Thank you, Madam Chair. As a member of the Loudoun County School Board, I make the following disclosure to the school board and to the general public in connection with the item on tonight's agenda regarding employee salaries, the budget, and or health insurance, and any other discussion that may include or affect salary and benefits for LCPS

[00:07:46] employees. Specifically, my spouse, my minor children, and I are enrolled in LCPS health insurance that may be affected by any potential changes to employee salaries, the budget, and or health insurance. Additionally, my sister-in-law is an LCPS employee who does not reside with me and is not dependent on me. These subjects include thousands of employees while in excess of the statutory three employees whose interests may be affected, of which my spouse, my minor children, my sister-in-law, and I am included. I can and will participate fairly objectively and in the public interest. This disclosure will be reflected in the public records of the clerk of the school

[00:08:24] board for five years. Thank you, Vice Chair Donohue. Mrs. Griffiths. Thank you, Madam Chair. As a member of the Loudoun County School Board, I make the following disclosure to the school board and to the general public in connection with the item on tonight's agenda regarding the budget and or health insurance and related benefits and any other discussion that may include or affect benefits for LCPS employees. Specifically as a school board member, I am eligible to receive health insurance and related benefits as an LCPS employee. These benefits, however, affect thousands of employees well in excess of the statutory three employees whose interests may also be affected,

[00:09:01] of which I am included. I can and will participate fairly objectively and in the public's interest. This disclosure will be reflected in the public records of the clerk of the school board for five years. Thank you. Thank you, Mrs. Griffiths. Ms. LaBelle. Thank you, Madam Chair. As a member of the Loudoun County School Board I make the following disclosure to the school board and to the general public in connection with the item on tonight's agenda regarding the budget and/or health insurance and related benefits and any other discussion that may include or affect benefits for LCPS employees specifically as a school board member I am eligible to receive health insurance

[00:09:39] and related benefits as an LCPS employee in addition as a former LCPS employee I as well as my spouse receive Medicare Advantage insurance benefits through LCPS these benefits however affect thousands of employees well in excess of the statutory three employees whose interest may also be affected of which my spouse and I are included I can and will participate fairly objectively and in the public interest this disclosure will be reflected in the public records of the clerk of the school board for five years thank you

[00:10:14] Ms. LaBelle, Ms. Chernoff. Thank you, Madam Chair. As a member of the Loudoun County School Board, I make the following disclosure to the school board and to the general public in connection with the item on tonight's agenda regarding the budget and or health insurance and related benefits and any other discussion that may include or affect benefits for LCPS employees. Specifically as a school board member, I am eligible to receive health insurance and related benefits as an LCPS employee. These benefits, however, affect thousands of employees well in excess of the statutory three employees whose interests may also be affected of which I am included I can and will participate fairly objectively and in the public interest this disclosure will be reflected in the public records of the clerk of the school board for five

[00:10:53] years thank you we will move on to agenda item number three approval of the consent agenda board members are there any changes to be made to the consent agenda seeing none before we vote on the consent agenda we have two proclamations to read the first proclamation recognizes January 27th 2026 as International Holocaust Remembrance Day in Loudoun County Public Schools and will be read by Mr. Pepper. Thank you. Whereas Tuesday, January 27th, 2026 is International Holocaust Remembrance

[00:11:32] Day commemorating the genocide of six million Jews and millions of other victims by Nazi Germany and honoring the liberation of Auschwitz in 1945. And whereas the Holocaust resulted in the systematic persecution and murder of six million Jewish men, women, and children, as well as millions of others targeted by the Nazi regime, including Romani people, people with disabilities, LGBTQ plus individuals, political dissidents, and others. And whereas on this anniversary, we emphasize the importance of Holocaust education to ensure that future generations

[00:12:07] understand the atrocities of the Holocaust and the importance of preventing such events from happening again and whereas it is the duty of schools to educate students about the Holocaust to ensure that lessons of history are learned and to inspire students to devalue diversity empathy and to recognize and reject anti-semitism and hatred whereas Holocaust education helps students learn about the consequences of prejudice racism anti-semitism and intolerance and fosters a commitment to human rights and dignity for all people whereas anti-Semitism has no place in Loudoun County Public Schools or anywhere as we

[00:12:45] remember and honor those who perished in the Holocaust and reject and condemn hate speech, racial slurs, anti-Semitism, and any action or behavior that is discriminatory and now therefore be it resolved that we, the Loudoun County School Board, do hereby proclaim January 27, 2026 as International Holocaust Remembrance Day throughout our school division, and we urge all students, staff, and community members to honor the memories of those killed during the Holocaust and to engage in educational activities that affirm the value and contributions of people of Jewish ancestry, their vibrant communities, and traditions.

[00:13:26] Thank you, Mr. Pippa. We will now move on to the second proclamation, which recognizes January 19th through January 23rd, 2026 as no name calling week in Loudoun County Public Schools. This proclamation will be read by Mr. Svensson. Thank you, Madam Chair. Whereas nationwide, about one in five high school students reported being bullied on school property in the past year, and more than one in six high school students reported being bullied electronically in the past year, including through texting and social media, and whereas name calling or verbal aggression, including insults, threats, and verbal

[00:14:03] abuse is a component of bullying. Name-calling becomes bullying when there is a repeated pattern and a power imbalance, making the target feel defenseless and shifting the interaction from playful banter to intentional harm that disrupts learning and well-being. And whereas every student has the right to feel safe, respected, and valued in their learning environment and to experience learning without disruption or discrimination. And whereas the No Name Calling Week recognizes that school-based programs that help strengthen young people's interpersonal and emotional skills including kindness and inclusivity practices, empathy, conflict management, and teamwork can

[00:14:39] reduce bullying. And whereas fostering a culture of belonging across all school communities provides an opportunity for students and staff to engage in learning and activities that promote these practices essential for building respect and understanding that creates strong supportive school communities. And whereas Loudoun County Public Schools will actively engage in the collective responsibility to teach and affirm No Name Calling Week by encouraging the school communities to refrain from name calling and hurtful language, participate in activities that celebrate kindness, acceptance, inclusion, and diversity, reflect on the power of words and

[00:15:15] impact they have on others, commit to fostering a positive and inclusive school environment year round, raise awareness for anti-bullying strategies and practices. Now, therefore, be it resolved that the Loudoun County School Board hereby proclaims January 19th through January 23rd, 2026, no-name-calling week across the division to endorse and ensure that every member of the LCPS school community feels supported, respected, and empowered. Thank you, Mr. Spinson. I will now entertain a motion to approve the consent agenda. Oh, Ms. Chernoff? So moved. Thank you. Mr. Pepper?

[00:15:54] Second. Thank you. We have a motion made by Ms. Chernoff to approve the consent agenda, it has been seconded by Mr. Pepper it has been properly moved and seconded to approve the consent agenda at this time we will take a vote to approve the consent agenda clerk please open the vote board members please record your vote clerk please close and display the vote oh Ms. Donahue would

[00:16:28] you please state your vote yes all right thank you madam clerk could you please display the vote all right that motion passes with Mr. Svensson Ms. Chernoff Ms. Chandler Ms. our chair Chandler Vice Chair Donahue, Mr. Pepper, Dr. Rasheed, and Ms. LaBelle voting yes, and Ms. Riccardi and Mrs. Griffiths are abstaining from the vote.

[00:16:58] Let's move on to item number four, our motion to convene a closed meeting. Vice Chair Donahue, do you have a motion? Yes.

[00:17:15] Thank you, Madam Chair. Apologies. A lot of windows open right now on my computer. I move that the Loudoun County School Board recess this public meeting and enter into a closed meeting pursuant to Section 2.2-3712 of the Code of Virginia for the following.

[00:17:43] Discussion of plans to protect public safety as it relates to terrorist activity or specific cybersecurity threats or vulnerabilities and briefings by staff members, legal counsel, or law enforcement or emergency service officials concerning actions taken to respond to such matters or a related threat to public safety.

[00:18:01] discussion of information subject to the exclusion in subdivision 2 or 14 of section 2.2-3705.2, where discussion in an open meeting would jeopardize the safety of any person or the security of any facility, building, structure, information technology system, or software program, or discussion of reports or plans related to the security of any government facility, building, or structure, or the safety of persons using such facility, building, or structure as authorized by section 2.2-3711 sub a sub 19 of the code of Virginia. Vice Chair Donohue has made a

[00:18:41] motion to convene a closed meeting. Do I have a second? Second. Thank you. I have a second by Ms. Chernoff. It has been properly moved and seconded that the Loudoun County School Board go into a closed session. Is there any discussion? Seeing none. Clerk please open the vote. Board members

[00:19:07] please record your vote. Ms. Donohue please state your vote. Yes. Clerk please close and display the the motion passes unanimously with all members present the board is now in a closed meeting if you are a member of the public I ask that you please leave the kindly ask that you please leave the room as the board is now in closed

[00:19:39] session so the public meeting reflect that no formal action was taken in the

[01:30:52] closed meeting second thank you mr. Bell I have the motion was made by miss Chernoff and seconded by Ms. LaBelle. It has been properly moved and seconded that the Loudoun County School Board adjourn the closed meeting. Is there any discussion? Seeing none, we will go ahead with the vote. Clerk, please open the vote. Board members, please record your vote. All right,

[01:31:24] Ms. Donahue, please state your vote. This is abstain. Thank you, Ms. Donahue. Clerk, please close and display the vote. The motion passes with Ms. Riccardi, Mr. Svensson, Ms. Chernoff, Chair Chandler, Mrs. Griffiths, Mr. Pepper, Dr. Rasheed, and Ms. LaBelle voting yes, and Vice Chair Donahue abstaining. Now, Ms. Chernoff, do we have another motion? Thank you, Madam Chair. I move that the following resolution certifying the closed meeting be adopted and reflected in the

[01:32:03] minutes of the public meeting, whereas the Loudoun County School Board has convened a closed meeting on this date pursuant to an affirmative record vote and in accordance with the provisions of the Virginia Freedom of Information Act and whereas 2.2-3712 of the Code of Virginia requires a certification by the school board that such closed meeting was conducted in conformity with Virginia law. Now therefore be it resolved that the Loudoun County School Board hereby certifies that to the best of each member's knowledge only public business matters lawfully exempted from open meeting requirements by Virginia law were discussed in the closed meeting to which this certification applies and only such public business matters as were identified in the motion conveying the closed meeting were heard

[01:32:42] discussed or considered by the loudon county school board. Thank you. I have a motion by Ms. Chernoff. Do I have a second? Second. Thank you. I have a second by Mr. Svensson. It has been properly moved and seconded that the school board certify the closed meeting. Is there any discussion? Seeing

none, we will go ahead with the vote. Clerk, please open the vote. School board members, please record your vote. Clerk, please close and display the vote. Oh, I'm sorry, Ms. Donahue, please state your vote.

[01:33:15] Abstain. Thank you. Clerk, please display the vote. The motion passes. Nine, voting yes, none voting no, and one abstention. With Ms. Riccardi, Mr. Svensson, Ms. Chernoff, Chair Chandler, Mrs. Griffiths, Mr. Pepper, Dr. Rasheed, and Carrie LaBelle voting yes, and Vice Chair Donahue abstaining for the vote.

[01:33:43] With that, we will recess the meeting for dinner and we will reconvene at 6 30. The board is now

[01:33:51] in recess.

[02:03:28] Good evening. The school board is coming out of recess at this time. Thank you. Before we begin tonight, I want to take a moment to acknowledge a tragic loss in our school community. Earlier today, a student was struck and killed by a vehicle near one of our schools.

[02:03:50] On behalf of the school board, I want to express our deepest condolences to the family and to the entire school community who are grieving at this time. We are holding you in our thoughts, and we grieve with you. Please join me in a moment of silence to remember the student and to acknowledge the heartache and sorrow being felt across our community.

[02:05:08] Thank you. We will continue with item 7, which is the Pledge of Allegiance and National Anthem. Tonight, the National Anthem will be performed by Forte, Heritage High School's Advanced Choral Ensemble. Forte is Heritage High School's Advanced Choral Ensemble comprised of students in 10th through 12th grade.

[02:05:28] Many of these students have participated and will participate in All-District Chorus, All-Virginia Chorus, Virginia Music Educators Association Senior Honors Choir, and the American Choral Directors Association Regional and National Honor Choirs.

[02:05:45] Forte consistently earns superior ratings at the District 16 choral assessment, which takes place every year in March. These dedicated students take pride in their work, and they are honored to be here this evening with their teacher, Kristen Sini.

[02:06:02] Welcome and thank you for being here tonight. Please stand for the Pledge of Allegiance.

[02:06:40] It was beautiful.

[02:08:16] Thank you so much. We will continue with the next item on our agenda, item 8, our Gifted Education Advisory Committee update.

[02:08:40] The Gifted Education Advisory Committee will be presented by Wendy King, Gifted Education Supervisor, Patty Peterson, Gifted Education Advisory Committee Chair, and Gifted Education Advisory Committee Member, Jennifer Shea. Good evening.

[02:09:12] I'm pleased to be here in my role as Gifted Education Supervisor, supporting the ongoing work of the Gifted Education Advisory Committee. This committee brings together families, educators, and community members who share a commitment to strengthening gifted education across the division.

[02:09:32] Their work reflects a range of perspectives grounded in a common focus on student learning and growth. I'm pleased to introduce our GIAC chair, Patty Peterson, along with our executive committee

member, Jennifer Shea, who will share the committee's update this evening.

[02:09:50] Good evening. I'm Patty Peterson, the GIAC Chair, an LCPS resource teacher, and the parent and grandparent of gifted learners. Thank you for this opportunity to address the board.

[02:10:06] We are here this evening to share some information about the work of the Gifted Education Advisory Committee, make some recommendations about gifted education in LCPS, and highlight some of the accomplishments of the gifted staff and students. And I want to add that I'm also the former third grade teacher of one of your new board members.

[02:10:25] So I'm feeling my age this week. The Gifted Education Advisory Committee serves as a support group to review and make suggestions about gifted programs and to promote community awareness of gifted education. School personnel, both teachers and administrators, community members, and parents and family members serve on the committee.

[02:10:49] Good evening. I'm Jennifer Shea, a middle school gifted educator and the parent of gifted learners. These are the norms that GIAC has established as a way for us, as a group, to conduct business efficiently and effectively. In LCPS, the development of gifted education programs and protocols is a deliberate and strategic process.

[02:11:11] Our work is grounded in multiple frameworks that guide our efforts to make services equitable, rigorous, and responsive to the diverse needs of gifted learners. We align closely with the Virginia Department of Education's regulations for gifted education with a focus on maintaining compliance and promoting consistency across the division.

[02:11:30] Our practices are also shaped by the LCPS strategic plan and the superintendent's post-entry plan, both of which emphasize equity, access, and excellence for all students. The LCPS local plan for the education of gifted students and our mission statement provide a clear vision and direction for our work, while best practices in the field and guidance from the National Association of Gifted Children help us stay at the forefront of innovation and effectiveness.

[02:11:58] Together, these frameworks inform a comprehensive and thoughtful approach to gifted education, one that is not only compliant, but also aspirational. Our protocols are designed to identify and nurture potential in students from all backgrounds, ensuring that every gifted learner has access to the opportunities and support they need to survive, thrive.

[02:12:19] To ensure that our gifted learners do thrive and reach their full potential, it's crucial to implement educational programs tailored to their unique needs. According to the Davidson Institute, gifted education programs should encompass enrichment, acceleration, and advanced curriculum.

[02:12:39] Let's explore how the LCPS gifted program integrates these essential components and more. Enrichment and extension opportunities go beyond the core curriculum. Acceleration moves students through the curriculum at a faster pace and or introduces them to coursework at an earlier age.

[02:12:58] And advanced curriculum challenges students to explore topics of study in more depth and complexity. These opportunities provide intellectual stimulation, nurtures students' interests, and taps into students' creativity. As you can see here, the LCPS Gifted Program and Services address each of these components.

[02:13:20] We have also included the additional component of talent development, or front-loading, which is a research-based educational best practice in which students are exposed to and practice new or essential skills that will support future learning. Experts in the field of gifted education point to the practice of front-loading as a promising strategy for shrinking excellence gaps and developing talent.

[02:13:48] GIAC meets five times per school year. Meetings give members and participants opportunities to work in small groups to discuss issues related to gifted education and make recommendations about LCPS gifted services. Committee work is grounded in best practices and gifted education.

[02:14:03] To stay abreast of the current research and best practices in the field, the committee invites experts within LCPS and outside experts to share their expertise at the meetings. Here are some of the topics that the committee has addressed or will address this school year.

[02:14:19] We did an introduction to the LCPS Ombudsman, the LCPS Special Programs Fair, review of math pathways and progression, which was conducted by the LCPS Math Office, gifted teacher and student panel discussion, and gifted program priorities.

[02:14:38] Our next meeting is January 15th at Watson Mountain Middle School. Dr. Amy Shelton, the Executive Director of John Hopkins Center for Talented Youth, will join us and talk about failure, a stepping stone to success. She will address how true success is built through the learning from setbacks.

[02:14:54] She will also discuss ways to help highly capable students grow by embracing mistakes as part of the learning process. We also hope to join forces with SEAC in the spring again to host a joint meeting and continue our collaborative work on supporting students who are twice exceptional, students who are both gifted and have learning differences.

[02:15:14] Partnering with SEAC reflects our commitment to inclusive, cross-functional collaboration that ensures all gifted learners, regardless of background or need, receive the support and opportunities they deserve. I'm going to walk you through some of this

[02:16:23] Oh, I apologize. To inform continuous improvement and future planning. Based on these themes and feedback shared throughout this year's GEAC meetings, we have put together a set of recommendations to help strengthen and sustain gifted services across LCPS.

[02:16:42] The first set of recommendations focuses on the conditions that support high-quality gifted programming. The committee emphasizes sustained attention to resources, staffing, and dedicated spaces to ensure consistent access for students at all schools. There is also a continued focus on strengthening identification and services for highly capable learners from historically underrepresented groups, while expanding advanced coursework with special programs across grade levels.

[02:17:09] Finally, these recommendations highlight the importance of coordination with other division initiatives so that gifted education remains aligned with the broader instructional and equity goals. Additional recommendations focus on strengthening how we support gifted learners academically, socially and emotionally through collaboration and shared responsibility.

[02:17:30] The Advisory Committee emphasizes building capacity among staff through coordinated professional learning, clearer communication and shared tools that help families better understand gifted instruction and services. There is also a strong focus on meaningful family engagement and community partnerships that extend learning beyond the classroom.

[02:17:50] Finally, the recommendations reinforce the importance of continued input and attention to advanced learners, including ensuring that advanced readers have access to appropriate challenge and growth opportunities.

[02:18:06] Now we want to highlight some of the accomplishments of gifted staff and gifted learners during the 2026 school year. As you can see, there are a number of accomplishments represented here across grade levels and schools.

[02:18:25] These examples show how gifted programming supports a range of student interests from academic competitions and creative work to applied STEM and community service. Across elementary and middle school, students are engaging in learning that asks them to think deeply, solve problems, and share their work beyond the classroom.

[02:18:45] Together, these highlights reflect a program with a focus on deeper learning, application, and student engagement. We would like to acknowledge the members of our team who represented and presented at state and national conferences this year and the team of Spectrum students who are committed to making playgrounds more inclusive.

[02:19:13] They have been fundraising for an adaptive swing and presented their ideas to the Loudoun County Board of Supervisors. And finally, we would like to extend our congratulations to Patty Peterson, who accepted her Virginia Association for the Gifted Teacher of the Year Award at the annual Virginia Gifted Conference in October 2025.

[02:19:37] It was a wonderful occasion, and she was able to share this honor with her family, and her granddaughter was extremely proud. So thank you for your time and support of Gifted Education LCPS.

[02:19:56] The work of the Gifted Education Advisory Committee is driven by a shared commitment to equity, excellence, and opportunities for all gifted learners. We look forward to returning in June for our next update, where we'll continue to share progress, insights, and perspectives from our community.

[02:20:15] Until then, we remain dedicated to nurturing the potential of gifted learners across the division. Thank you very much to the GIAC team for your presentation, and congratulations, Mrs. Peterson. Job well done. Are there any questions or comments from the board? Mr. Pepper.

[02:20:34] First of all, thank you for that presentation. As a parent of a child who has just started the fusion program this year, I can tell you that the work that you all are doing is excellent. The other two things I want to say are, one, I'm very much looking forward to the presentation at Watson Mountain Middle School.

[02:20:50] One of the hardest things for gifted children to have is to kind of abandon that fixed mindset that a lot of them have and learn to succeed from failure. I'd also like to say that I'm very delighted to be joining you on this journey as a school representative to Gifted Education this year.

[02:21:05] So thank you guys so much. Thank you. Mr. Svensson. I just wanted to exercise a point of personal privilege and say hello to my third grade teacher, Mrs. Peterson, and say thank you for your years of service to LCPS and congratulations on the recognition from VA Gifted.

[02:21:26] Thank you so much. Seeing no further questions, We will continue on with item number nine, staff recognitions. For our one LCPS spotlight tonight, we will discuss belonging at Evergreen Mill Elementary School.

[02:21:42] This item will be presented by Evergreen Mill staff and students, including Principal Jennifer Theason, Assistant Principal Samantha Schray, Special Education Dean Raynell Brown, fifth grade teachers Bruce Blakeney and Robin Meha, second grade teacher Patricia Wright, early childhood special education teacher Christina

[02:22:05] Crowder, and their second and fifth grade students. Good evening, everybody. My name is Jennifer Thiessen, and I am the very, very proud principal of Evergreen Mill Elementary School in Leesburg, Virginia. We are honored to be here today to celebrate our staff and students and our work towards building a strong sense of belonging in our school community. Next slide, please.

[02:22:41] Please take a minute to review our agenda for this evening. We're excited. I will introduce our staff and students, talk about our connection to our strategic plan, give a little bit of a why behind why it really matters and why we give so much time to a sense of belonging, and then we're going to talk about two programs that we are very, very proud of, our Python Pals program and our Kindness Club.

[02:23:06] Next slide, please. I'm proud to introduce our staff and students who've joined us today. Our dedicated administration team is here to include Mrs. Shray, our assistant principal, Mrs. Brown, our SPED dean. To share about our Python PALS program, we have Mrs. Wright, a second grade teacher, Mr. Blakeney, a fifth grade teacher, Grant, a second grade student in Mrs. Wright's class, and OCL, a fifth grade student in Mr.

[02:23:34] Blakeney's class. To share about our kindness club, we have our ECSE teacher, Mrs. Crowder, our fifth grade teacher, Mrs. Mejia, and our fifth grade students, Keegan and Spencer. I brought everybody with me tonight. Next slide, please. The initiatives that you will hear about today are deeply connected to LCPS's Strategic Plan for Excellence. It aligns directly with Goal 1, Empowered Students, and Action 1.3 of Care for Students. In LCPS, our MTSS framework encompasses

[02:24:07] multiple layers of support, which include RTI, SEL, and PBIS. Both of the programs that you will hear about today support the SEL and PBIS aspects of our MTSS framework. Our Python Pals program allows for cross grade level collaboration and partnership among students during their morning meeting and our kindness club exemplifies the cultivation of an inclusive environment that meets the needs, the unique needs of our students in our special education programs as well as

[02:24:42] instilling leadership skills among our fifth grade students. Next slide please. We want to take a moment to reiterate the importance of creating an environment where a sense of belonging is at the core of what we do each day and why this work matters above all else. Next slide please. At Evergreen we are rooted in the idea that belonging is the work. We know through experience and research that real student achievement and confidence and that achievement cannot occur without first feeling a sense of belonging, safety, and love. It is a literal stepping stone to

[02:25:21] achievement and self-actualization which is why we prioritize it every day at Evergreen through multiple opportunities. Next slide please. And if you want to take a moment to read this quote on your own. When we first met with our staff in August at the beginning of the school year we really took time to intentionally reflect on the idea of self-worth and the notion that when students are anchored by a sense of belonging they feel worth a sense of dignity and will put forth the effort needed for achievement. We call ourselves a school family and we live that every day in our words our actions and the structures that we've created for ourselves and for our students. Next

[02:25:59] slide, please. So the first program we're going to talk about is our Python PALS program. So Mr. Mrs. Excuse me, Mrs. Wright, Mr. Blakeney, Grant, and OCL are going to come up and talk about our Python PALS program. Next slide, please. Good evening, and thank you for having us tonight.

[02:26:21] Sorry about my voice. Six kids out. My name is Mrs. Wright, and I teach second grade at Evergreen Mill Elementary. My class is partner this year with Mr. Blakeney's fifth grade class. My name is Bruce Blakeney. As Mrs. Wright shared, my class is paired with her class for Python PALS this year. I'm pleased and proud to introduce you to one of our groups, two amazing young gentlemen. Next, you'll be hearing from Mrs. Wright's second grade student, Grant, and my

[02:26:50] fifth grade student, OCL. Next slide, please. Hello, my name is Grant. I'm in second grade in Ms. Wright's class. Python PALS meets once a month, and you get to spend time with your buddy.

[02:27:12] It is really fun. My buddy is Oseal, and he's in fifth grade. We usually have, we do fun projects with our buddy. So far, we have colored a hand with things that we have in common. We wrote a candy cane with our favorite things all about fall.

[02:27:34] And we made a snowman. I say hi to Oseal when I see him around the school. It is cool to know an older kid. Hi, my name is Ocel, and I'm in fifth grade in Mr. Blitney class.

[02:27:56] Python pals is when you have to be respectful with all the people. If someone doesn't have a friend, they can join your group if you have one. If someone doesn't know something about school, you can help them. I like that we share things and we learn about the other person. I'm excited to see my Python pal.

[02:28:13] When the day comes, I feel happy when I see Grant. I say hi to him. I feel happy because here's my body, and we talk and we share things. We have a lot of things in common, like video games and food.

[02:28:38] Next slide, please. And now I have the honor of introducing Ms. Crowder and Ms. Mejia to talk about the Kindness Club. Hi, I'm Christina Crowder.

[02:28:58] I'm one of the early childhood special education teachers. Kindness Club was developed to help integrate our preschoolers into the school community by giving them opportunities to engage socially with peers outside their classrooms. Through this experience, my students have gained new play partners and role models while building meaningful connections they might not otherwise had the opportunity to have.

[02:29:22] Over the last few years, Kindness Club has continued to grow every year with more fifth graders participating and excited to help our youngest learners. Hi, I'm Ms. Mejia. I'm one of the fifth grade teachers.

[02:29:38] And I just wanted to share that Ms. Crowder and I have worked really hard to get the fifth graders excited. And it does grow more and more each year. I watch them come back to our classrooms, excited to talk about the preschool students that they work with. And they apply the skills they're learning in there within the classroom.

[02:29:56] They're more patient with each other. They're more accepting. And they really want the best for those students. They see them in the hallways. They wave to them. They watched them at the assembly the other week and wanted to sit with them and include them in the assembly so that they could take part.

[02:30:12] Next slide, please. Hi, my name is Spencer, and I'm a part of Kindness Club. I'm a fifth-grade student in Ms. Mejia's class. My favorite thing about Kindness Club is getting to hang out with the kids who aren't my age.

[02:30:28] I love playing at the sensory table, and some of the preschool rooms even have wooden car tracks. Those are really fun. Being in Kindness Club has taught me that every kid is different. Some can do things that are really advanced, and some are still working toward their goals, and that's okay. Everyone learns at their own pace.

[02:30:44] Working with the preschoolers has made me a better student because I've learned to be patient. I try to show them how to do something, but I let them try first before I jump in to help. It's awesome to see them grow and learn, even if sometimes we have to chase them around when they get the Zoomies. Thanks for letting me share my Kindness Club experience.

[02:31:02] Hi, my name is Keegan, and I am part of Kindness Club. I'm a fifth-grade student in Mr. Davis' class. My favorite thing about Kindness Club is watching how the preschoolers are growing and developing. It's cool to see how they are turning into kids like us, and it makes me think about what it was like when I was younger.

[02:31:24] I've learned a lot being in Kindness Club. Before, if I saw someone struggling, I would just do it for them. But now I've learned to give them a chance to try first. Frustration can help you learn, and that's something I didn't realize before. Working with the preschoolers have made me a better student because I understand that struggling is okay.

[02:31:44] It's part of the process. I also think it's fun to see how they look at things in a different way. Their minds work in such a cool and creative ways. Kindness Club has taught me patience and how it is important to let others learn in their own way. Next slide, please.

[02:32:02] Would you guys mind giving my kiddos a round of applause? In closing, we want to extend our sincere thanks to each of you for your continued support, guidance, and collaboration.

[02:32:26] Your leadership and commitment enable us to provide meaningful programs and strong learning opportunities for our students at Evergreen Mill and throughout LCPS. We are incredibly proud, as you can tell, of our school community, and we value our partnership with the board. We would be honored to welcome you to Evergreen Mill family anytime.

[02:32:45] Our doors are always open. Thank you so much. If you have any questions, we're happy to answer them. Otherwise, have a great evening. Thank you, everybody. Thank you. thank you to our Python professionals and our Python scholars you guys are incredible thank you for showing your expert showcasing your experience and how you're building community at evergreen mill are there any comments or questions from the school board and sure enough thank you madam chair and thank you evergreen mill and boys wow so impressive so brave thank you for

[02:33:22] being here and thank you for being kind and for caring about kindness and for taking care of each other it's really important and I love what you said about how frustration can be a point of beginning a learning journey and that's really true and you're very very young to understand that so I think that you have bright things ahead shout out to my Leesburg community for doing amazing work and we look forward to seeing the work in person thank you so much for all you do. Mr. Spenson. Well congratulations all this is an amazing program and especially great to hear from the students about what the program

[02:34:00] means to them I was wondering if you all have had the opportunity to discuss the kindness club and Python pals with other schools and LCPS if you can teach you know folks how to start up these programs if they don't have them already I've had several schools reach out to me asking how we got this program up and running so I've shared kind of what has worked for us and we've had to tweak it as the years have gone on to accommodate for a fifth grade schedule and preschool schedule so

[02:34:37] we've absolutely shared this we've even connected with the middle school across the street because some of our kindness club members wanted to continue this on into middle school and figure out a way to do this at their new school seeing no further questions thank you so much for your presentation that was lovely we will move on to our next item which is 10.01 our student school board representative's comments. Tonight, our student school board representative is Andrew Webb

[02:35:11] from Lightridge High School. Andrew is a senior at Lightridge. He spends his time being very engaged with his peers and community through his membership in National Honor Society, Student Council, and FCA. He is also a three-year member of the Lightridge varsity baseball team. Outside of Lightridge, Andrew is a member of the Young Men's Service League, a service-based organization dedicated to mothers and sons completing service hours together. Andrew spends most of his time training for baseball and watching sports with his family. After he graduates from high school in June,

[02:35:49] Andrew will continue his athletic and academic career at the University of Lynchburg, where he will pursue a doctor of physical therapy degree while also playing baseball. Andrew is honored to be selected as the Light Ridge Student School Board Representative this year and is dedicated to leaving a positive impact on his community and school. Welcome, Andrew. We're happy to have you here. The floor is yours. Thank you. Good evening, Dr. Spence, Chair Chandler, members of the school board and LCPS community. I'm honored to be here tonight as a Light Ridge High School Student School Board Representative. I'm excited and proud to report all the amazing accomplishments our community

[02:36:27] at Light Ridge has accomplished in the past year. On September 23rd, 2025, Light Ridge was recognized as one of the top high schools in the nation by the U.S. News and World Reports. That same report listed Lightridge as the 22nd best high school in the Commonwealth, Virginia. I'm also pleased to report that in December of 2025 issue of the Northern Virginia Magazine, Lightridge was listed as the fifth best high school in Northern Virginia.

[02:36:51] Furthermore, in December of 2025, Lightridge achieved the category of distinguished based on the results from the Commonwealth School Performance and Support Framework. These glowing awards demonstrate the students and staff at Lightridge are exceeding the state's expectation for achievement, growth, and readiness. During the 2025 spring sports season, our boys soccer team posted a record of 20, 2, and 1, winning the district, regional, and state championships.

[02:37:16] The Lairridge boys soccer team was honored on November 7th during the halftime of the varsity football game, where they received their state championship ring. This fall, our culinary students arts program have been putting their skills to work as they prepared 72 meals for our Cooking Up Hope program, which provided Thanksgiving meals to those in our community who are experiencing homelessness. Our terrific yearbook program achieved a trophy class in VHSL publications for their 2025 yearbook. This is the highest classification a high school yearbook can achieve. Our percussion ensemble and choir ensemble were selected to perform at the VME conference in Norfolk in Virginia. To my knowledge, this was the first time one high school has had

[02:37:53] two different music programs selected to perform at the annual state conference. Our band, the Light Ridge Marching Storm, have been selected to perform in the London New Year's Parade on January 1st in the year 2027. Light Ridge was also awarded their first Purple Star Award for creating a welcoming and supportive environment for our military-connected students and families.

[02:38:12] At Light Ridge, we challenge all our students and staff to be the LIGHT. LIGHT is the acronym we preach every day, and it stands for leadership, inclusivity, generosity, honesty, and thinker. We strive to make Light Ridge a place where students, parents, and staff want to be, not a place they have to be. Our BOLTS strive to create a welcoming environment where all students feel they belong and have a voice. Personally, at this time next year, I will be attending the University of Lynchburg, where I hope to be as welcomed by the administration there as I am here at Lightridge. Our faculty and staff are dedicated to helping students achieve their academic goals and developing them into young, successful leaders. As a student, I appreciate all the

[02:38:48] opportunities Lightridge has provided me. I will make sure to take these valuable lessons I have learned in LCPS and use them as I move forward in my life. Lastly, I'd like to give a special thanks to Dr. Hitchman and Ms. Barbaro for selecting me as our high school student board representative this experience has been an honor and i am very grateful for this opportunity thank you all for your time thank you for being here andrew and thank you for sharing your lightridge experience with us it was lovely to hear from you tonight um we'll move on now to item 11.01

[02:39:23] our superintendent's report presented by dr aaron spence superintendent thank you madam chair members of the board as always it's my pleasure to share some good news from around our school division this evening i'll begin with students in ben shoebridge's technical education class at Brambleton Middle School, who got a hands-on lesson in native plants and plant care just before the winter break. With support from our facilities operations team, which initiated this activity and invited student engagement, the class planted several native chokeberry shrubs on the Brambleton campus. This activity aligns with LCPS's commitment to sustainable practices, including the use of

[02:40:02] native species to support local wildlife. The project strengthened our students' understanding of environmental stewardship and complemented the work of the school's green team. Our green teams, coordinated by the Office of Sustainability, empower students and educators to collaboratively explore and address sustainability and environmental challenges. In addition to enhancing Brambleton's campus, the shrubs will also support pollinators and birds. Congratulations to Paul Peterson, Woodgrove athletic trainer, for his recent induction into the Virginia Athletic Trainers Association Hall of Fame. Mr. Peterson has been an LCPS athletic trainer first at Potomac Falls

[02:40:40] and then at Woodgrove for nearly 30 years. At the VATA annual meeting held in Hampton, Virginia earlier this month, Mr. Peterson was commended for his commitment to delivering the highest quality care to student athletes and for his unwavering professionalism. Woodgrove and Loudoun County are fortunate to have Mr. Peterson serving in this role. Next, Catherine Tenuzzo, school psychologist at sully and guilford elementary schools is this month's shine award winner she was nominated for her commitment to students families and the sterling community according to her nomination in just the past six months she has participated in 17 school events and led multiple efforts to

[02:41:18] help parents better understand the importance of mental health whether she's supporting families cheering on students or even serving as the timekeeper for the inaugural sterling area of Futsal

competition, Ms. Tenuzzo's dedication to the school communities is unwavering.

[02:41:34] To help make the SHINE celebration even more special, Guilford's Futsal student-athletes joined the event, and to honor her SHINE recognition, she received a gift coordinated by the Loudoun Education Foundation and sponsored by Cigna. SHINE, which stands for Spotlighting Heroes in Education, is a joint LEF and LCPS initiative recognizing LCPS staff members who go above and beyond in support of our students and the community. Members of the LCPS community, including other staff members, students, and parents are invited to nominate LCPS staff who shine by visiting the website you see there. LCPS is kicking

[02:42:11] off its annual awards program and it's time to celebrate the incredible people who help make our schools excel. With categories ranging from teachers and principals to bus drivers, custodians, IT pros, and more, there's a place and an opportunity to recognize nearly every LCPS superstar staff parents students and community members are invited to nominate outstanding employees whose work truly stands out nominations are open until friday february the 13th to nominate someone simply visit the website you see there and then finally this evening i'd like to highlight the upcoming lcps school business partnership executive council breakfast which

[02:42:51] will be held on thursday april the 16th this event is a time set aside to celebrate the powerful impact that collaboration between our schools and community partners make possible. This annual gathering shines a light on the businesses, organizations, and leaders who help expand opportunities and support student success for students all across our division. We look forward to honoring this shared commitment and to honoring the incredible work we accomplished together.

[02:43:19] For our business partners who may be interested in sponsoring a table, please visit the LCPS School Business Partnership website shown here for more information. Madam Chair, that concludes my report. Thank you, Dr. Spence. That brings us to item 12, public comment. The procedures for public comment. Thank you for engaging with the school board through the public comment process. The school board welcomes comments from Loudoun County residents and believes that strong community engagement and outreach are important components of a successful school system. Speakers must limit

[02:43:55] comments to the time allotted. Based on the number of speakers we have tonight and the agenda this evening, all speakers have been allotted one minute each first public comment. Please be advised that speakers who miss their time slot will not be called at a later time. Decorum and civility. All audience members shall maintain civility, decorum, and respect for the functioning and dignity of the school board at all times. Please remain seated unless arriving, departing, speaking at the podium, or during a break. Violations of civility, decorum, and respect include shouting, heckling, jeering,

[02:44:33] applause, or other noise which disrupts or delays the meeting, obstructing speakers from being able to see the school board and vice versa, interrupting speakers, attempting to speak when not called to do so by the chair, and approaching a speaker or otherwise attempting to intimidate, disparage, or distract a speaker, staff member, or other meeting attendees. Speakers should refrain from vulgarity, obscenities, defamation, profanity, and other like breaches of respect, nor may speakers target, criticize, or attack individual students or individual division employees during public

[02:45:11] comment. As a reminder, School Board Policy 2520 states speakers may not target, criticize, or attack individual students during public comment. Speakers should communicate those concerns to their school principal or an appropriate school official. The school board requests that comments on an

individual student or employee related matter not be shared at public meetings where the disclosure could violate applicable confidentiality requirements. I do want to take a moment to clarify a few things. As has been explained previously, speakers can personally identify

[02:45:51] a student or employee without stating a student's or employee's names. That is, personally identifiable information is any information that a reasonable person can link together to pinpoint an individual student or employee and where that individual student or employee is known to others in their school and surrounding community based on the context that is shared. The school board welcomes you to share your concerns, but ask that, to the extent you have prepared remarks that target, criticize, or attack any individual students or employees, you generalize such comments to ensure

[02:46:30] compliance with board policy. For example, remarks that target, criticize, or attack a student or an employee or a student or an employee from a specific named school or a student or an employee with any characteristics where the information would personally identify that student or employee to others in the school or broader LCPS community would violate school board policy. However,

[02:47:00] Comments that discuss general concerns with students or employees at schools and do not target, criticize, or attack an individual and identifiable student or employee are permissible. Under school board policy, I, as the school board chair, am charged with the responsibility to maintain order during the school board meetings.

[02:47:23] Accordingly, when reasonable, I will warn of breaches of decorum, civility, and respect and ask speakers to redirect their comments. prior to possibly discontinuing individual speaking privileges or taking other actions to preserve the civility decorum and orderly conduct of the meeting.

[02:47:40] Such action includes calling a recess in order to maintain and/or restore order. If speakers fail to comply with board policy regarding public participation, you will receive a warning and request to redirect and generalize your comments.

[02:47:56] Should you fail to redirect or generalize your comments after the warning, you may be asked to yield the microphone at which time you should yield the microphone as well as the floor and take your seat and i will then call the next speaker to the extent necessary i will also warn of breaches of decorum civility and respect from attendees prior to taking any actions to preserve the orderly conduct of the meeting speakers should face the dais and direct their comments to the school board per school board policy 2520 members of the school board will not

[02:48:31] answer questions or respond directly to the public during public comment period violations of decorum and civility by any meeting attendee may result in the chair directing staff to remove the attendee from the remainder of the meeting repeated or persistent violations of decorum or civility by the audience may result in on the decision of the chair public comment being tabled until a later point in the meeting's agenda limiting the number of attendees in the meeting room during public comment for safety reasons or the public comment period ending for the evening distribution of

[02:49:06] materials to school board members copies of materials for board members should be given to the public information officer in the media box at the back of the boardroom before the start of the meeting please provide 12 copies of the materials under no circumstance may a speaker approach the dais the public is reminded that access to school board meetings is available through LCPS TV on Comcast

Channel 18 and 1070 HD and Verizon Fios Channel 43. The live stream of the meeting may be viewed on the website. We look forward to hearing your comments. We will now start

[02:49:45] with our virtual public comment. Caitlin Iberman will be our first speaker, followed by Shubha Bandywad. We do not have a virtual public speaker by that name. Shubha Bandywad, followed by Brandy Hi, good evening chair and members of the board.

[02:50:10] DN36 is a walkable zone that meets LCPS policy 6530 criteria, yet it was excluded from consideration entirely. Why was only one neighborhood added for a motion and who made that decision? That exclusion is indefensible. This board is being asked to approve a permanent rezoning using incomplete data while ignoring DN36.8.

[02:50:31] We are in the same zip code as Madison Trust, demonstrating clear geographic and community alignment. Proceeding this way violates your own policy standards. Table this decision. Require a full transparent evaluation of DN 36.8 and all affected zones before any vote.

[02:50:49] Otherwise, this vote goes on record approving a rezone without fairness, transparency, or adequate data. Thank you. Thank you. Brandy White, followed by Natalia Harry. We do not have a virtual public speaker by that name.

[02:51:07] Natalia Harry, followed by Miraha Patel. Hello, my name is Natalia. I live in Brambleton Town Center, DN 36.8, and I walk my daughter to Madison Trust Elementary every single day, regardless of the weather. I'm here because I love that our neighborhood was designed to let kids walk to school safely, using the tunnel without crossing any busy roads.

[02:51:31] Plan 28 will end this. It will take our neighborhood out of Madison Trust's zone. Some families like mine would lose the walk-to-school route we use every single day. Instead, our kids would be put on buses even though the school is nearby and the walking is safe.

[02:51:47] Keeping DN36.8 at Madison Trust makes sense. It protects safe and proven walk zone, supports LCPS policy to keep students close to home and avoid unnecessary disruption. I also worry that some of the data used for this decision wasn't complete and transparent. and it does not reflect our real experience as daily workers.

[02:52:04] We need more careful process, and I truly believe we can find a better solution. Thank you so much for your time and your service. Thank you. Meera Patel, followed by Indriprid Kaur. Good evening.

[02:52:22] I'm a Willisford Grant resident and a parent of two children currently at Madison's Trust. I'm urging you to revoke the recent rezoning that moved the grant out of Madison's Trust. The previous board's rezoning was meant to ease capacity concerns at Madison's Trust, but it overcorrected dramatically, removing over 400 students from one of the county's highest performing schools.

[02:52:43] The result has been severe staff implications with dozens of staff present tonight pleading for stability. Keeping the grant at Madison's Trust is the only balanced solution. In the short term, it prevents an excessive drop in enrollment that is now threatening staff positions. In the long term, our student population is aging out with half of the grant's current students in fourth and fifth grade.

[02:53:04] With low turnover, enrollment from our neighborhood will naturally decline over the coming years, providing sustainable capacity relief without repeated disruptive changes. Please do not repeat past

mistakes seen with the Heartland community by swinging too far in the opposite direction. Thank you for your consideration.

[02:53:20] Thank you. Indirpreet Kaur, followed by Surabh Arora. We do not have a virtual public speaker by that name. Surabh Arora, followed by Pavel Romanenko.

[02:53:43] We do not have a virtual public speaker by that name. Pavel Romanenko, followed by Janina Romanenko. Hello, good evening. My name is Pavel Romanenko, and I'm also a resident in Bramleton. I live in DM 36.8.

[02:54:00] And I want to highlight the student safety, because that should come before capacity numbers or convenience. DM 36.8 is a walking zone to Madison Trust. Our children today walk safely through the safe tunnels. Under the adopted plan, they will become instead drivers or bus riders.

[02:54:16] And that will be across Belmont Ridge Road and Creighton Road. Those roads have been already identified as safety concerns in Loudoun County studies. So this is really a dangerous step backwards in safety. So our question to the board is very simple. Why are students who can safely walk today are going to be forced into buses across known dangerous hazardous roads while more distant zones are reconsidered?

[02:54:41] If this is a reopening decision about the rezoning, we would really kindly and respectfully request that the safety, proximity, must be related to all effective zones, not just for one. Thank you for your time. Thank you.

[02:54:57] Janina Romanenko, followed by Kubra Yichar-Adeniz. Good evening. My name is Janina Romanenko, and I also live in the N36.8 in Bramlington. Safety and geography both point to the same conclusion.

[02:55:15] The N36.8 is directly adjacent to Madison Trust, and it's part of its work zone. The views of zones are under consideration, are one of two to three miles away. Reassigning walkers while prioritizing further bus dependent zones contradicts basic safety logic.

[02:55:33] There is also a strong community connection. Madison Strasse in our voting proceeding, this is where our community votes. This school is part of our daily and civic life. If the board is considering rezoning to reduce disruption, then removing walkable access from the N36.8 creates more disruption, not less, and increases safety risk.

[02:55:55] We are asking for one thing. If any zones are being reconsidered, the N36.8 must be included, and safety might be the first criterion, not the afterthought. We are asking to ensure that no future vote occurs without full safety, walkability, and enrollment analysis.

[02:56:15] Thank you. Kubra Yijer Edinez, followed by Mehmet Edinez. Dear Chair and members of the board, my child currently attends Medicine Trust Elementary School and we live on Lavalette Square in Bramleton.

[02:56:35] We are less than a mile away from the school and we walk every day in which my child spends active, social, and deeply connected to our neighborhood and community. Under the proposed rezoning, this would mean my son spends most of his time in a school bus instead of spending his precious time on healthy walking and no neighborhood connection.

[02:56:59] Also, as a taxpayer, this decision is also difficult to justify. Today, our walk-to-school arrangement costs nothing for the county, but this rezoning would cost hundreds of thousands of dollars per year in recurring transportation costs. And this data is not supported through evidence. So we respectfully ask the board to reconsider this rezoning and keep walking. Thank you. Mehmet, Adinez,

[02:57:31] followed by Kumar, Yaralag Adal. All right. Can you hear me? Yes. Thank you. I have communicated my concerns to you through various emails, and I have demanded that you provide the evidence base that you use to justify your claims, which seems to be plausible but not rational, not evidence-based, because the evidence that you have used are weak, and none of the committee members are convinced that, you know, you're making a rational decision informed by

[02:58:08] evidence. You have failed to provide evidence to us so far, but yet you are using all evidence that's, you know, at your disposal to come to us and then push this argument over us. So we are in the walk-in zone and we are in the same zip code and then we demand that, you know, we keep our students in our school zone. And I encourage everyone to read this, reconsider this decision and I am traveling right now. I am sorry, but you know, all of our neighbors have spoken up and they have provided an evidence to you and their concerns have been communicated. Thank you. Kumar

[02:58:43] Yarla Agada. We do not have a virtual public speaker by that name. Thank you. We will now move on to our in-person public comment. Paige Riemann followed by Tara Greenwald. Good evening members of the school board. My name is Paige Riemann and I've been teaching first grade at Madison's Trust for eight years. Since opening our doors 10 years ago, our staff and families have poured their time, trust, and hearts into creating a place where children feel known, safe, and

[02:59:19] inspired to reach their fullest potential. Our dynamic culture has been built intentionally, year by year, relationship by relationship. The recent boundary changes have shaken our staff to core and compromise that culture losing 35 plus members of our macaw flock was not a situation we had anticipated it's been difficult and discouraging not because we resist change but because we care so deeply about what we've built we believe that patience is the answer allowing two years for enrollment numbers to stabilize would give us time to adjust thoughtfully and sustainably with time we can preserve what makes mte special while moving forward together we are functioning at

[02:59:56] at 113 percent capacity and I think we do it well. Thank you. Thank you. Tara Greenwald followed by Casey Studolu. Hi it's Tara from Willowsford Grant back again for the fifth time. On December 16th plan 280 was put through to rezone the Willowsford Grant and zone DN 36.8 to different schools.

[03:00:24] The aftermath of this decision has been absolutely devastating. Our top performing school is losing 35 of its amazing staff members due to it going down to 70 percent capacity this is an unnecessary overcorrection we are a strong close-knit community and ideally i would love a delay on this decision to let the projections work themselves out in time if there is no chance for a delay please vote to keep willowsford grant at madison's trust it is the only way to keep madison's trust under

[03:00:57] 100% capacity while minimizing disruption since we only have 189 students. Please erase this devastating mistake that was made on December 16th and delay the decision for two years or move the grant back to Madison's Trust. Thank you. Casey Stadola followed by Colleen Sally. Hi my name is Casey Stadola and I'm a fourth grade teacher at Madison's Trust Elementary School. I began my teaching career at Madison's Trust in 2018 and have stayed in the same position for eight years.

[03:01:33] I found my home there, and to tell you the truth, it's because of our community. The school board's decision to reestablish our attendance zones threatened to break apart this very community. I started at MTE as it was finding its groove as a large new school. I have had a front row seat watching our families and staff connect, grow, and persevere through each challenge we have faced.

[03:01:50] From COVID car parades to sold-out staff volleyball games, watching MTE become what it is now is something that I am both in awe of and also proud to be a part of. I understand the board might feel this rezoning supports reducing our large numbers, but changing the boundaries removes both students and staff who have found safety and comfort in our community.

[03:02:06] Not only that, but Madison's Trust is a top-performing school. Why disrupt our culture of excellence to solve a temporary problem? In closing, the majority of our students are fourth and fifth graders. Cutting our school by 40% is an unnecessary overcorrection. We are asking the board to delay the rezoning for the next two years as the numbers will naturally correct themselves. Please keep our community intact. Thank you. Thank you.

[03:02:27] Colleen Sally, followed by Erin Hughes. Good evening. My name is Colleen Sally, and I am your 2025 Teacher of the Year. I've been a teacher for 22 years, and 10 of those years have been at Madison's Trust.

[03:02:46] I was lucky enough to be part of the inaugural staff, and tonight I'm here to ask you to leave our attendance zones as they are. This rezoning would displace more than 400 children and over 30 staff members who have been a part of a school whose test scores are some of the highest in the county. We are ranked 8th in the state of Virginia and have been recognized as a distinguished school in Virginia two years in a row.

[03:03:05] This is not by accident, but because of the relationships, stability, and teamwork that exists within our walls. This kind of community and success is not built overnight. It took years of intentional work, commitment, dedication, and collaboration. We were not asked for our opinions, yet we are the ones who will have to live with these consequences.

[03:03:22] Please don't dismantle the successful, loving school community. Listen to us and see all of us. Please remember that behind every number is a child, a teacher, and a family who simply wants to stay together. Thank you. Thank you. Erin Hughes, followed by Nimesh Patel.

[03:03:41] Hi, my name is Erin Hughes. I've been teaching for four years. This is my second year as a fourth grade teacher at Madison Trust. The team lead, and depending on your decision tonight, someone who may lose their position at this amazing school. Growing up in Brambleton, I'm no stranger to the redistricting that happens in this county.

[03:03:59] I experienced it in elementary, middle, and high school, losing classmates, friendships, and strong relationships with teachers at each of those life stages. And here I am, 10 years later, now potentially having that same experience as a teacher. I urge you to think of us as a school, a staff, a community, a family, not just numbers that need to be moved.

[03:04:19] Yes, we are big. Presently, fourth grade is a team of nine teachers. It may seem large to you, but it works. Our status as a top performing school, eighth in the entire state of Virginia, is no accident. Our state rank is tied to the group of teachers and staff that has cultivated an amazing environment of hard work and excellence.

[03:04:37] Please defer this decision for a year or two and let our numbers naturally work their way out. Thank you. Thank you. Nimesh Patel, followed by Tiffany Rutledge. Hello, LCPS board member. Welcome to the new board member also.

[03:04:53] We are here to request only postpone and delay for the Medicine Trust rezoning because the rezoning was rushed and not accurate, lack of data and lack of analysis. What we are asking only to postpone and delay the MTS rezoning.

[03:05:09] Thank you. and you can see there's so many people here. We have another event next month for the school, it's called This Is Us, and This Is Us. So just keep it us. - Thank you, please, community members, please don't clap.

[03:05:25] If you wanna show support, this is perfectly acceptable, but please don't disrupt the meeting, it makes it take longer. Now, Tiffany Rutledge, followed by Andreas Pilages. - Hello, my name is Tiffany Rutledge, and I have proudly been a part of the MTE family four and a half years. When I was first, when I was in my last years of college and grad school, I wasn't certain that I would take a route of being an educator post-grad. That was until I entered Madison's Trust Elementary School as a student teacher. Within one week, I had no doubt that it was the path for me. I had incredible mentors who launched me successfully into a teaching career. Over the next few years, through various mentors within the school,

[03:06:03] along with programs and initiatives set up through a dedicated, through dedicated staff members, I became a teacher I am proud of today. MTE became a family I could lean on through challenges and a community to help me thrive, encouraging me to become a better teacher and human on the daily. With the upcoming changes, the school and family that have supported me will change significantly.

[03:06:23] We are asking you, as a high-performing school in the county, to reconsider the changes you are making to our boundaries and delay the vote for two to three years as our numbers level out. Please take into consideration the profound effect this will have on our staff and the culture we have worked to build. Thank you for your time. Thank you. Andresa Pilajev, Followed by Lynn Alexander.

[03:06:46] Good evening, board. I'm a member of the N36.8 community. The school board ordered a walkability study because walkability was clearly an important factor in this decision. If it were not important, the study would not have been requested in the first place. That means the quality and integrity of that data truly matters.

[03:07:04] Yet, the data used to remove the N36.8 was collected on a single call this morning at 25-degree weather. In those conditions, fewer families chose to walk. This does not show a lack of walkability, it shows a limited and flawed snapshot. A credible walkability study would be conducted over multiple days across different seasons, and both in the morning and in the afternoon.

[03:07:26] One point in time cannot support a permanent removal of a safe walk zone. Anyone who lives in this community knows that on normal afternoons, there are hundreds of children walking, and you can't even ride a bicycle through the tunnel because you have to walk it. We respectfully asked the board to delay rezoning, finish the job they started, and actually complete a comprehensive study on walkability and make, before making an irreversible decision.

[03:07:49] Thank you. Lynn Alexander, followed by Vamshi Singhi-Reddy. Good evening. I live in Willisford-Grant and my son attends Madison's Trust. After December's rezoning vote, over 400 kids and 35

teachers at Madison's Trust spent winter break fearful about forced displacement from a home they love.

[03:08:12] We're caught in a cycle of overcorrection and we're watching history repeat itself. In 2023 a previous board emptied Elaine Thompson classrooms to 70 capacity when they rezoned the heartland neighborhood. Out last month's vote moves Willisford Grant kids like placeholders to fill those vacancies. This overcorrection fills seats in one school to near capacity only to drain another school to under capacity all at the expense of the kids and teachers' stability while the delay would be ideal. I understand the board wants immediate relief. Keeping us at Madison's Trust provides that relief while honoring the pleas of all the staff you will hear from tonight. If we stay, Madison's Trust remains under 100% and disruption to students and teachers is minimized.

[03:08:49] I urge you, please reverse the December vote. Whether you delay the decision for two years or move Willisford Grant back to Madison's Trust, an easy solution that follows the numbers is well within reach. Thank you very much for your time and consideration. Thank you. Vamsi Sinji Reddy, followed by Chris Stevenson.

[03:09:09] Hello. My name is Vamsi. I have two kids who go to Madison Trust. They do work every day, irrespective of the weather. And the country, the county invested millions in pedestrian infrastructure, including tunnels to make walking safe and practical.

[03:09:27] Eliminating the walk zone now undermines the investment and violates LCPS policy 6530. And rezoning does not solve the problem here of this problem, especially there has been car lines, congestion, and all those things have not been done over the seasons.

[03:09:43] That's when they should be doing. Decision, the decision moves backwards and work should be prioritized and at very least this decision should be delayed and evaluate real data and actual enrollment numbers so that, yeah, thank you.

[03:10:01] Thank you. Chris Stevenson followed by Nagendra Srinivasa. Good evening. Thank you for your long hours away from family serving our children. I'm Chris Stevenson, LCPS parent and member of Civic Ground, which encourages school boards across the country to challenge the president's assaults on our children's education and future. Tonight, I'd like to call out his persistent lies about the January 6th insurrection. The new White House website calls it a patriotic event, blames

[03:10:38] Democrats, and promulgates other dangerous lies. Our children must hear from the school board, the adults in the room leading this school system, whether you agree with the president's lies about January 6th or whether you believe the truth. Loudoun County students are bombarded daily with lies from the most powerful government on earth. Importantly, their bright future lives on truth and dies on authoritarianism's falsehoods. I urge you to be brave and courageous. Thank you very

[03:11:12] much. Thank you. Nagendra Srinivasa, followed by Kara Schuller. Good evening, respected board members. I'm a resident of zone DN 36.8 with two kids, first grader and second grader, going to Madison Trust Elementary School. Loudoun County invested millions of dollars in pedestrian infrastructure, including the tunnels, specifically to make walking to Madison Trust Elementary safe and practical. Eliminating the walk zone now directly undermines that investment and sends

[03:11:49] the message that walkability is not actually being prioritized. Even where it is intentionally designed to work, I request the respected board members that DN 36.8 be added back to the Madison Trust

or at least delay the process to make a complete and fair evaluation, collecting all the true data points. Also, I live on Brooksbank Square facing North Star Boulevard.

[03:12:15] We can literally, from the patio, we can literally see the Madison Trust building, and it is hard to believe that we will be not part of Madison Trust. Thank you. Thank you. Kara Schuller, followed by Kristen Lloyd. Good evening.

[03:12:37] I am a resident of the grant and have three children at Madison's Trust. The December 16th decision has impacted far more than the families who have spoken up since rezoning began. As you can see tonight, it has affected the entire school community. Education looks different today. Teachers work tirelessly to educate our children while keeping them safe and engaged.

[03:12:55] A school's stability and success doesn't happen overnight. It takes time to build strong school teams, grade-level teams, and departments that support consistent student learning and growth. With one vote, that stability was taken away from Madison's Trust. While we often hear about the importance of retaining teachers, this decision has instead dismantled the school and created uncertainty for staff, students, and families.

[03:13:15] This disruption is unnecessary. I urge you to consider the significant impact on the school community and either delay the implementation or, if immediate relief is needed, move the grant back to Madison's Trust to restore capacity and consistency across the Dulles North elementary schools. Thank you for your time and consideration.

[03:13:31] Thank you. Kristen Lloyd, followed by Debbie Langsam. Hi, I'm Kristen Lloyd.

[03:13:47] I have three kids at Stuart Weller Elementary and a toddler at home. I'm here again to discuss the Stuart Weller Bell schedule. For new members, LCPS moved to a staggered schedule in 2022 due to transportation issues. Stuart Weller is one of about 20 schools, which is 30%, with the earliest start, unfairly burdening the same segment of families indefinitely.

[03:14:11] The Transportation Division is under the false impression that the majority are okay with this. We started a petition to ban families together and demonstrate our frustration. Nearly 200 families have signed. During boundary discussions, families repeatedly commented about not wanting an earlier schedule.

[03:14:31] This is telling. New boundaries present an opportunity to change the Stuart Weller Bell schedule. The Transportation Division has seemed apathetic to finding a solution. You, the school board member representatives, were elected to represent us.

[03:14:47] Thank you. Debbie Langsam, followed by Sarah Eichelberg. Good evening.

[03:15:03] My name is Debbie Langsam, and I am incredibly fortunate to have been a part of the staff at Madison's Trust since it opened in 2016. I've been a full-time substitute across Cat TA and have been a cross-cat teacher for the last four years. Just nine months ago, I stood in this very room for a much different majority's occasion.

[03:15:21] I was honored to have been selected as the 2025 New Teacher of the Year for elementary schools, an honor that humbles me every day and one that I don't take lightly. Tonight, I stand here for a far different reason. Due to the school board's decision to rezone hundreds of our students, I am one of many teachers and staff in jeopardy of being involuntarily de-staffed in June.

[03:15:40] Like countless others at our school, I've chosen to remain at Madison's Trust year after year. We stay because we love what we do, we love who we get to do it with every single day, and most importantly, we love who we do it for, our incredible students and their families. Madison's Trust is truly one of a kind.

[03:15:55] We are our family, and on December 16th, a 30-second vote by the former school board shattered our family. We are here tonight to implore you to reconsider that decision. Give us the gift of time. I have Sarah Eichelberg followed by Andrea Friday.

[03:16:15] - I live in Willowsford Grant and have three children at Madison Trust. My family believes in kindness, working hard, having common sense, and being courageous. And I'm here tonight being courageous for our kids, community, and teachers.

[03:16:31] I understand boundary decisions are never easy, but the final vote in December rezoned 40% of Madison Trust students and therefore dismantling the staff as well. One of the largest rezoning impacts to a school that did not involve a new school build. Madison Trust is a highly accredited and highly ranked school for years now, even with the high attendance rates.

[03:16:50] The families, teachers, and students have built something truly special, and disrupting that has real consequences. My daughter's in fourth grade and has always gotten the attention and help she's needed. Not once did it change or diminish due to overcapacity, and that's because the school is filled with the best teachers and staff, and that will now be changing due to your zoning decision.

[03:17:09] I respectfully ask you that you reconsider this boundary decision and keep Willisford Grant at Madison Trust, Using both facts and common sense ensures decisions that truly serve. Andrea Friday, followed by Wesley Spano. To all the new board members, welcome.

[03:17:34] My name is Andrea Friday, resident of Willisburg Grant Community and proud Mighty McCaw parent of a second grader at Madison's Trust Elementary. My son is on an IEP and has thrived at MTE with the amazing teachers and supportive staff. I truly believe this is why he loves going to school. I'm sure he is one of many with this scenario, But why would we want to disrupt the routine of so many of our children and impact the jobs of several dedicated teachers and staff to overcorrect an occupancy concern?

[03:18:00] With the new members joining the board, I would like to strongly encourage a re-vote to support amending Plan 280 to keep zones DS 08.1, 0.2, and 0.3 with the 189 children who live in the Willowsford Grant Village at Madison's Trust Elementary School.

[03:18:15] Thank you for your commitment to ensuring our children continue a strong, positive, and uninterrupted educational experience. Thank you. Wesley Spano, followed by Curilos Daniel. Hi, my name is Wes Spano, and I'm the parent of three kids, one graduate and two currently at Madison's Trust.

[03:18:37] I live in the grant community, and I'm here once again to talk about the recent rezoning decision that has ended up negatively impacting Madison's Trust in terms of students, staff, and teachers. I would support delaying the decision or moving the grant back to MTS.

[03:18:54] It's about solving a problem. Leaving the grant in MTS solves the short-term problem of not reducing the population too much, which allows students, teachers, and administration to remain together, as does delaying the decision.

[03:19:09] The data shows that it also solves the long-term problem because it allows population changes to settle, and the grant community is stable with low turnover and the elementary school population is

aging. This will help keep student population manageable for years to come and delaying the decision allows everything to settle and stabilize.

[03:19:31] Please don't make the mistake of over- Thank you. Akira Lose Danielle, followed by Joshua Stevenson. Joshua Stevenson, followed by Zeal Somani.

[03:19:53] Good evening. I respectfully urge the board to issue a clear and courageous statement in affirming that our district supports educators and staff who speak the truth about key events in American history and current affairs in an effort to uphold the Constitution and our nation's core democratic principles.

[03:20:09] Our students deserve an education rooted in facts and democratic principles, not lies. To that end, LCPS teachers must be protected when they speak about these established realities that Donald J. Trump lost the 2020 election and attempted to overturn its results, that he encouraged and incited the violent January 6th insurrection in which his supporters sought to block the peaceful transfer of power guaranteed by the Constitution, that he pardoned those convicted for their roles in the attack on our capital, thus legitimizing political violence, undermining the rule of law. This is not about partnership. This is about truth, integrity, and protecting the ability of our educators to do their jobs without intimidation or retribution. When we allow political pressure to dictate what

[03:20:48] can be taught or said, we fail our students and risk normalizing dishonesty and authoritarianism. Thank you. Thank you. Zeal Samani, followed by Ella Stevenson. - Good evening, everyone.

[03:21:03] We are being rezoned from Madison Trust, a walkable school from our community. My son, a current third grader, has walked there since kindergarten, making him independent and confident. Walker data from our community was collected on one of the coldest days in December and does not reflect normal year-round walking patterns.

[03:21:22] If the goal is to reduce car-line congestion, removing established walkable neighborhoods based on skewed data is counterproductive. Walkers reduce traffic and improve safety. Madison Trust is a Brambleton school. Walkable Brambleton communities belong there and not rezoned away.

[03:21:40] Please delay this rushed rezoning, follow the MTE staff guidance that you see over here, and keep our community together. Together, we all rise. Thank you. - Thank you. Ella Stevenson, followed by Jamie Woolert.

[03:21:56] - Good evening. First off, I want to thank you all for your hard work and sacrifice to help make the school system run smoothly. My name is Ella Stevenson, a member of the group Civic Ground and a senior at Loudoun Valley High School. As a student, I want to make sure that my teachers feel protected and safe to teach me the truth, particularly in regards to politicized events that President Donald Trump has cast doubt on, including but not limited to the fact that Donald Trump lost the 2020 election and that he continues to lie about it, the fact that Donald Trump incited an insurrection aimed at dismantling one of the main pillars of our democracy, the peaceful transfer of power.

[03:22:33] No matter what he says, these are facts. And as a student in USGov right now, I believe my teacher and any other should feel safe saying so. The president has thrown our facts-based education into chaos, harming me and my peers' education, and thus the future of our country.

[03:22:49] Please push back and do it as in your power to protect facts, and in so doing, protect the students of this district. Thank you. Thank you. Jamie Woolert, followed by Sierra Cabresis. Hi, back for the fifth time. I live in the Willisford Grant, and I have three students at Madison's Trust.

[03:23:08] What happened at Madison's Trust was unusual. We wouldn't all be here if it wasn't. Removing 40% of students and disrupting 35 teachers is disruptive and unnecessary. The original staff plans proposed moving either the Brambleton Zone or Willisford Grant.

[03:23:26] It wasn't until mid-process that a new proposal, Plan 280, suggested moving both zones out. During the December 16th meeting, a plurality of board members, six of the nine, voted to only move one zone.

[03:23:42] Unfortunately, that vote got split with four votes in favor of the Willisford grant and two in favor of the Brambleton zone. Only three board members, a minority, voted to move both zones. Again, the majority of board members voted to only move one zone.

[03:23:59] The majority of you lost. Please write this wrong, delay, or move the grant back. Thank you. Sarah Cabresis, followed by Kay Hogan. I have two girls at Madison's Trust, and I live in Willows for the grant.

[03:24:17] I grew up around here, and I know rezoning is a necessary evil, but this feels different. In October, the two staff plans proposed that only one neighborhood should be moved, not both. This made sense. Fast forward to Thanksgiving. A new plan was presented out of left field moving both neighborhoods, Plan 280.

[03:24:35] We all then had to scramble to explain that this is a huge overcorrection. Madison's Trust is a well-oiled machine and definitely doesn't need 400 kids moved. Dr. Rashida and Ms. Griffiths asked for a delay and were denied. Plan 280 got approved days before winter break. This should have been a happy time.

[03:24:52] Instead, classroom parties were full of tears and concern from students, parents, and teachers. If you're not going to delay, please fix this mistake. Amending Plan 280 to keep Willowsford Grant at Madison's Trust keeps it under capacity. We have only 189 kids and half of them are fourth and fifth grade.

[03:25:09] half this still provides madison's trust the relief you're looking for with as little negative impact as possible thank you thank you kay hogan followed by ramon abroy hi everyone how did we get here back in the fall two plans were presented and proposed that one of two neighborhoods should be moved from madison's trust to provide some capacity relief this made sense in november a new plan was presented plan 280 that moved both neighborhoods we tried to explain this was an

[03:25:44] overcorrection. Capacity relief does not require moving 400 kids and reducing capacity by 400%. We asked for a delay and were denied. Plan 280 got approved in December. It was not a consensus. One vote made the difference. This is an unprecedented result. Look around. And it warrants an unprecedented response from you all today. Delay the decision. Listen to your community, please um delay the decision or amend plan 280 to keep willows for the grant it's the only neighborhood that allows the capacity at madison stress to be under a hundred percent this is not

[03:26:22] a necessary evil what you're seeing here today do the right thing ramon obroy followed by tanya varner good evening everyone i'm ramon obroy we all are seeing the uh affected family because of

the medicine trustee zoning i would like sorry i would like to request you guys to delay this decision for two years as Willows Ford and our Madison Brambleton both the communities have kids who are gonna age out of in elementary school pretty soon they are mostly in third fourth and fifth grade so we'll request if we can

[03:26:59] distillate it if we can't I will appreciate if we can keep the walkable school the school and the community which are in the same city and same zip and the same school rather than keeping the city school which is in a different school thank you thank you Tanya Varner followed by Hamad Kamal good evening members of the board my name is Tanya Varner I am a teacher at Madison's Trust Elementary School and a resident of the Brambleton Town Center area thank you very much for the opportunity to speak tonight I respectfully

[03:27:38] request that the board either delay or amend attendance rezoning plan 280 to include the over 200 students in the walkable neighborhood across from Madison's Trust, also known as DN36.8. Plan 280 overcorrects our school's attendance and significantly reduces enrollment to the point that we could potentially lose 35 of our amazing staff. It also displaces students from walkable neighborhoods and adds unnecessary bus routes.

[03:28:04] Keeping this neighborhood at Madison's Trust will limit drastic cuts to the Madison's Trust dedicated and high-performing staff, avoid additional transportation costs, and maintain walkability for students. I urge you to make the right decision and support students and staff by either delaying or making the amendment to include DN 36.8 in the Madison's Trust School Zone. Thank you. Thank you. Hamad Kamal followed by Sachin Kadam. Sachin Kadam followed by

[03:28:36] Hadi Nguyen Rontano. Good evening members. My name is Sachin Kadam. As a parent of one child and resident of dn36.8 i'm here to request you to revert your decision of moving out our zones from the medicine trust school and delay it if possible i request you to reanalyze the statistics on workers and the car commuters for different weather days pick up and off of times we always walk to school as it takes hardly 10 minutes from our home to reach out reach out to the school

[03:29:14] our community was planned or is planned considering the medicine trust school for our kids roads and tunnels are developed so that our kids can walk to the school and this results in reducing the number of accidents i don't see a great reason to move us to a different school which is two two miles away and bringing another community which is five miles away and it will definitely increase the traffic congestion as a parent we can only request you guys. You all are wise enough to treat us all, everybody equal. Thank you. Hadi Wurantano followed

[03:29:51] by Natalie Brandon. Good evening. My name is Hadi. I'm a resident of DN 36.8. I respectfully urge the board to reconsider the rezoning of DN 36.8 as part of the plan 280. At a minimum, I request that the board delay the final decision until a comprehensive and statistically valid walkability study is conducted. The current data is simply insufficient, and it's really unfair for us if you guys will use that as a decision-making. With that being said, I ask all the board here

[03:30:31] to make a wise choice on the voting power, and I believe and I trust you, you'll make a decision that is well-informed and also objective. Thank you. Thank you. Natalie Brandon, followed by Natalie Marty Rosen. Good evening. My name is Natalie Brandon and I'm currently a first grade teacher at Madison's Trust. This is my third year back in the classroom as a teacher. Just after COVID hit our country,

I began my journey at MTE as a teaching assistant. As I was going through my own personal struggles, Madison's Trust became a calm, safe place and not just a job. The

[03:31:08] administration and staff became a family. Being back in the education arena after several years felt refreshing. Serving in several different positions at MTE reinvigorated my passion for teaching with the full support of the admin and staff i was able to go back to being a full-time teacher without those vital years where our school became my family i would not be where i am today we are asking to delay the rezoning of our zone of our school there's a very human element of family camaraderie team chemistry and support that cannot be captured in a quantitative analysis or spreadsheet students and their families are being greatly impacted and the staff is being greatly

[03:31:43] impacted as well. Thank you. Natalie Martirosian followed by Killen Diaz. Good evening. My name is Natalie Martirosian. I'm a fifth grade teacher. This is my eighth year teaching at Madison's Trust. I wanted to express my concern about rezoning. We have incredible admin and staff that demonstrate exceptional leadership and immense passion for teaching. Most importantly, we have students and parents who love our school. We are truly a tight-knit community.

[03:32:14] Many siblings of students are looking forward to being in our upper-grade classrooms. It breaks my heart to think so many kids excited to be here would no longer have that opportunity. Also, as a mentor, I have wonderful protégés on my team that are incredible teachers. It would be a huge loss for them or any of our colleagues or admin to have to leave.

[03:32:34] Our school is more than a school. It is a family, a positive work environment where everyone is delighted to go to work every day. I ask you to please delay rezoning. Let our staff who love working at our school continue to do so. Let all of our students and families stay where they belong.

[03:32:50] Thank you. Thank you. Kellen Diaz, followed by Ankur Muntrey. Hello, my name is Kellen Diaz. I am an EL teacher, and I have been at Madison's Trust since the school first opened its doors.

[03:33:09] Over the years, I have watched this building become more than our school. It became a place where every child is known, valued, and believed in. Today, we are one of the top schools in the state, not by accident, but because of the people who make it what it is.

[03:33:25] At Madison's Trust, administrators, teachers, students, and parents work together as a family. Our students succeed because they belong, they are known, and they are supported. We all belong to Madison's Trust, and we all support each other.

[03:33:55] Rezoning threatens to take our successful school family away. It could also take me away from Medicine's Trust. Thank you. Ankur Mantri, followed by Raki Gupta. Raki Gupta, followed by Karen Vaidya.

[03:34:21] Good evening, members. I am from DN 36.8. I'm mother of two boys, goes to Medicine's Trust. I'm here today to speak on behalf of our community, a close, connected, and walkable community that has always been tied to this school.

[03:34:41] This school is not just a building to us. It is the heart of our community. Families live in the same zip code. Children walk together every morning through the tunnel that was built specifically so kids could safely walk to the school. We have a school that is walkable, cost-efficient, and reduces the traffic.

[03:35:01] We have children who feel safe and connected. We have families deeply invested in this community. Moving our closest community away from its neighborhood schools sends a message that proximity, connection, and community ties do not matter, but they do matter to parents, to educators, and most importantly, to our children.

[03:35:19] I respectfully urge the board members to reconsider or delay this decision. Please listen to the voices of this community. Thank you so much. Karen Vadia, followed by Brian Colloran. Brian Colloran, followed by Trey Evans.

[03:35:44] I'm a parent of three students at Madison's Trust, and I live in the grant. As someone that was deeply involved in the rezoning process, I can tell you the process is flawed. This includes illogical attendance projections, a final vote that was rushed, causing confusion amongst the board.

[03:36:03] And worst of all, it pitted two neighborhoods against each other and divided a community. Then you voted to move both. The final vote impacted 40% of Madison's trust, something that was never proposed by the staff. The result is what you see and hear tonight. Frustrated parents, confused students, and distressed teachers.

[03:36:21] We warned you that Plantuity was an overcorrection, yet here we are. This board has an opportunity to correct this and appease some and maybe even all of us. the delay option makes sense. We know the school can perform at a high academic level despite high attendance rates. If a delay is not possible, re-voting to keep the grant at Madison's Trust is the most logical solution and the only way to keep the school below 100% in all years.

[03:36:44] Do the right thing. Correct the overcorrection. Thank you. Tracy Evans, followed by Chris Countryman. Hello. I have a speech, but I'm not going to read it. I think the audience here speaks for itself.

[03:37:03] we don't understand this decision honestly we don't know why we're here this makes no sense we have ripped out 400 students 35 teachers from a top performing school why makes no sense it's simple this is an easy one I think it's really important for our leaders each and every one of you to admit when a mistake is made it's okay it's okay to make mistakes I don't think the board fully realized that they were decimating the school when they voted for these amendments.

[03:37:36] You can fix it. There's an option on the table. Dr. Rashid has put forth an amendment to reinstate the grant, or we delay. Keep everybody there. I know rezoning isn't fun, and I understand you have a long-term plan. I understand, but there has to be a better solution here. There has to be. Thank you. Thank you. Chris Countryman, followed by Erin McNamara. Good evening. On behalf of LEA,

[03:38:13] thank you for your service and for the opportunity to work together as we begin a new year to both returning and newly elected board members. Our educators and support professionals are committed to creating safe, welcoming, and academically strong schools for every student. I want to acknowledge the challenges inherent in your role and the reality that consensus is almost never possible. But as decisions are made, we value ongoing collaboration with this board and believe that the most effective decisions are informed by the perspectives of those who work closest with

[03:38:49] the students. These voices need to include staff across roles and buildings. We can better understand their experiences, concerns, and priorities related to student safety, school climate, and staff

retention. We look forward to continuing open, respectful dialogue as partners and serving our students, families, and community.

[03:39:09] Thank you, and we look forward to the year ahead. Thank you. Erin McNamara, followed by Sandy Sullivan. Good evening. My name is Erin McNamara, and I am a gifted resource teacher at Madison's Trust.

[03:39:25] Every day in our classrooms, we challenge our students to lead with critical thinking, creativity, and empathy, to pause before accepting the easiest solution, and to consider how their choices affect others. Tonight, we are asking the same of you. This rezoning decision affects roughly 400 students and nearly 35 staff members.

[03:39:45] These are not just numbers, these are real children, their families, and their educators, whose routines and relationships will be deeply impacted. Madison's Trust may be a large school, but it is a thriving one. It is joyful, efficient, and successful. Please don't disrupt what is working so well.

[03:40:02] We know difficult choices must be made, but we respectfully ask you to reconsider this decision. We are asking you to be the same leaders we challenge our students to be. Leaders who act with empathy, thoughtfulness, and creative problem-solving. Thank you. Thank you.

[03:40:18] Sandy Sullivan, followed by Jennifer Scott. Good evening. I'm Sandy Sullivan, Broadbun resident, third-grade teacher, and board member of the Loudoun Education Association.

[03:40:34] I'm speaking tonight to simply welcome this newly formed school board. You all have a lot of work ahead of you, which I know you are all well aware of. and the union looks forward to working with you in order to support our educators, families, and students. Our government relations committee will be in contact so we can continue to build the relationships we have built.

[03:40:52] To our three brand-new school board members, Amy McCarty, Ross Svensson, and John Pepper, we look forward to developing relationships with you. Please reach out if you have had any questions or want to discuss anything. Thank you for your past and future service. Thank you. Jennifer Scott, followed by Corey Brené.

[03:41:11] Good evening, my name is Jennifer Scott and I'm a teacher at Madison's Trust Elementary. My family is military and moving has been a normal part of life. New homes, new schools, new faces, always starting over. Now that we finally stopped relocating, Madison's Trust feels like home.

[03:41:27] We built our home in Brambleton Town Center so our children could walk to their schools. I teach here, I live here, I see my students not just in the classroom but at the grocery store or even on a walk with our dog. Even though our school is over capacity, we provide the best education, our students shine, our ratings are outstanding, and our teachers give everything every day.

[03:41:47] Due to rezoning, our school is facing de-staffing, and I will be one of those teachers affected. Now that we finally found our place, we are forced to start over again, leaving students and relationships that I deeply care about. We ask the board to please not rezone, let our numbers even out.

[03:42:02] This isn't just about rezoning, it's about the loss of stability, trust, and connection. Madison's trust is more than a building. It is our home, and homes should not be so easily broken apart. Thank you. Thank you. Corey Brunet, followed by Emma Iharu.

[03:42:20] Good evening. My name is Corey Brunet, and I'm an English learner teacher at Broad Run High School. Congratulations and welcome to new school board members Ms. Riccardi, Mr. Svensson, and Mr. Pepper, and congratulations, Ms. Chernoff and Ms. Chandler, on your re-elections.

[03:42:37] LEA is eager to work with all of you to make progress towards the goal of making LCPS the employer of choice in Northern Virginia. Each student in LCPS deserves educators who excel in their profession, are proud of what they do and where they do it, and most importantly, love children.

[03:42:55] A beautiful example of this is right in front of you, all these dedicated Madison's Trust educators here tonight. For some of you, this is the first time you will hear me say something that I say every time I speak at a school board meeting because it has been, is, and always will be true.

[03:43:11] LCPS will never outperform its educators. Thank you. Emma Ihara followed by Daniel or Dean Daniel. Good evening my name is Emma Ihara and this is my first year at Madison's Trust Elementary School as well as my first year of teaching.

[03:43:26] Being a completely new teacher I will lose my position at Madison's Trust Elementary unless the rezoning is delayed. I'm a graduate of LCPS as are some of my other first year teachers at Madison's Trust. I came back here to teach because I really enjoyed my experience as a student here from K to 12.

[03:43:44] I loved my elementary school and I'm still best friends with a few of the people that I went to elementary school with my heart breaks for our students who have been coming to Madison stress for years building close potentially lifelong friendships with their peers but who will now be forced to attend a school that they have no connection to or friends at I can't imagine how confused our walkers are knowing that they live close enough to walk to our school but will not have to take a bus every morning to go to a new school farther away MTE thrives on the community that we've built full of dedicated students and hard-working staff our test scores combined with the expressed love for our school from our students, parents, and staff should be enough to prove that it's not worth redistricting any of our students to fix a temporary numbers problem. I'd like you

[03:44:22] to reconsider. Thank you. Thank you. Dean Daniel, followed by Richard Stokes. Richard Stokes, followed by Stuart Curley. I'm sorry. Dean Daniel, please come on up. Thank you. My name is Dean Daniel. I've been studying why there is a large difference in academic achievement between racial groups. Pass rates on standardized tests range from 90% for Asians to as low as 70% for another

[03:45:00] racial group here in Loudoun County. What I've discovered is there's a 95% correlation between passing a standardized test and whether a child comes from a one-parent household or a two-parent household. It makes sense because a two-parent household has more money and time to spend on their child. The county school system, of course, can't replace a parent, but it can't provide things like one-on-one coaching during study hall to provide the same kind of push a second parent could provide this we this school system spends an enormous amount of money on very talented schools like academies and on special

[03:45:36] education it should pay an equal amount of time paying attention to the students that come from single-parent households it will go a long way to curing the racial disparity gap in Loudoun County school systems thank you thank you Richard Stokes, followed by Stuart Curley.

[03:45:54] Hi, my name is Richard. I'm a Willisford grant dad with two kids at Madison's Trust, kindergarten and first grade. Despite months of meetings and pleas from our community, the previous

school board rezoned about 40% of Madison's Trust students.

[03:46:12] An extraordinary change to force on just one school. This is a major overcorrection, tearing apart a community built over years and pitting neighbors against neighbors. And it's all driven by projections on an Excel spreadsheet.

[03:46:30] Projections that are imperfect and have been wrong before. In 2023, Heartland was rezoned away from Elaine Thompson for projected overcrowding. And now families are being moved back because it's underutilized. Please don't repeat that mistake. Pause implementation and delay this change.

[03:46:48] If you won't delay, keep the grant, 189 students at Madison's Trust to reach about 95% utilization with far less disruption. Thank you. Thank you. Stuart Curley, followed by Jill Hickman. Hello, I'm Stuart Curley.

[03:47:06] I'm with the Brambleton Town Center community. I've been involved in these processes for many years, as you can tell by the lack of hair. I have watched many. I've participated in many. I have never seen a situation where everyone wants things to stay the same.

[03:47:32] There's always fighting. When do you see the outpouring of the staff and all communities to say, we can make this work? Look at the history. It's happened before. Schools I've been involved with, schools surged, and they still thrived. Evergreenville, earlier this evening, that's one of those.

[03:47:51] Please take your time. Don't rush to make one amendment versus another. Please consider both options. If you do have to choose only one community, please consider the community where the school is located and where the kids walk to school.

[03:48:06] Thank you. Thank you. Jill Hickman, followed by Andrew Weiskopf. Good evening. My name is Jill Hickman. I am currently in my sixth year of teaching fifth grade at Madison's Trust.

[03:48:23] One of the primary reasons MTE is so successful is because of our cohesive teams. Our grade level and department teams are essential for students' achievement. As a team, we prepare lessons and activities that strengthen our instruction. Our students and teachers are part of a close community that I've never experienced before.

[03:48:42] Research shows that building a strong team can take several years. Time and effort has been dedicated to building these teams. It would be detrimental for every team in the building to begin again and hope to build the special magic that is Madison's Trust.

[03:48:59] While I know evening outer numbers is necessary, I am suggesting that it become a gradual process. Allow the students and families that are currently attending to stay. Over the course of a few years, the numbers will diminish, eliminating the drastic change for our students, families, and staff. Thank you. Thank you. Andrea Weiskopf.

[03:49:31] First, I'm a never married single parent, and my child holds a PhD from MIT in cellular biology. Regarding 13.11, charter schools are not public if they can refuse to work with students whom they do not deem a scholar using the word scholar for their students only is also insulting and demeaning

[03:50:01] finally historian Leron Bennett wrote an educator in a system of oppression is either a revolutionary or an oppressor what kind of school board will you be as for me long live the revolution black lives matter thank you board members at this time we will take a short recess and we will reconvene

[03:50:30] at 8 30. drop your glasses the board is back from recess please take your seats audience members

[04:03:58] please take your seats thank you the board is back from recess and we will continue with our information items beginning with 1301 the office of auditor generals 2025 annual report presented

[04:04:22] by Ahmad Woods, our Auditor General.

[04:04:49] Good evening, everyone. Madam Chair, new board members, welcome. Tonight, I am pleased to present the Office of Auditor General's Annual Report. This report reflects our commitment to transparency, accountability, and alignment with the one LCPS strategic plan for excellence. The purpose of the annual report is threefold, to provide transparency into the operations of the OAG, to demonstrate compliance with professional audit standards and to show strategic alignment with lcps goals this report has been prepared in

[04:05:27] accordance with policy 3410 office of the auditor general next slide please today's presentation will cover an introduction to the office of the auditor general our mission and vision a review of accomplishments for fiscal year 25 audit engagements completed and in progress goals for fiscal year 26 and an update on the my concern is hotline next slide please approved by the school

[04:06:03] Board in May of 2022, the OAG was created to provide independent assurance and consulting services that strengthen governance and accountability. We also manage the My Concern Is hotline, which was launched in January of 2023. Next slide. Our mission is to deliver high-performing internal audit services that add value and reduce risk. We support LCPS by evaluating risk management, control, and governance processes. Through these efforts, we promote

[04:06:40] transparency, accountability, and continuous improvement across the division. Next slide. Year review and accomplishments. In fiscal year 25, we finalized the OAG audit manual, launched our quality assurance and improvement program, and completed a conformance readiness assessment to align with the new Institute of Internal Auditors global standards. We also executed our annual audit plan, implemented post-audit surveys, and participated in an

[04:07:14] external peer review of the Santa Cruz Treasury Department. Next slide. Here are the audits the OAG has issued since our last annual report was presented. The audit of student placement policies and procedures, the audit of student software applications, the audit of IT third-party risk management, and the audit of staff support and advocacy resources.

[04:07:45] Next slide. We also have several audits in progress, including transportation management, register data and integrity, a review of school board and staff communication, and Jefferson Contracts Administration.

[04:08:02] Two items, security badging and school board communication are carryover audits from the fiscal year 25 audit plan into the fiscal year 2026 audit plan. Next slide.

[04:08:19] Our goals for fiscal year 26 align with the one LCPS strategic plan. We will focus on empowering students by auditing systems that support safety and equity, cultivating exemplary staff through professional development and QAIP enhancements, maintaining an enriched division by reinforcing safety and operational efficiency and engaging the community through transparent reporting and outreach.

[04:08:49] Fiscal Year 2026 Audit Plan. This plan includes engagements in governance and risk management, health and safety preparedness, workforce management, facilities and infrastructure, and professional learning effectiveness.

[04:09:06] These topics were selected based on risk assessments and stakeholder input and approved by the Legislative Audit and Policy Committee. Next slide. The hotline remains a confidential channel for reporting fraud, misuse of resources, and unethical behavior.

[04:09:28] Next slide. In fiscal year 2025, we received a total of five concerns, with most occurring early in the year. Despite outreach efforts, submissions remain low, which may indicate high satisfaction or low awareness.

[04:09:48] We will continue to update our marketing material and implement it in the schools and across the division facilities. We will also continue to monitor and enhance engagement. Next slide. This concludes our presentation.

[04:10:04] The full report can be observed on board docs and will be available on the OAG webpage in the coming days. Thank you for your time and continued support. I'm happy to answer any questions you may have. - Thank you, Mr. Woods. Board members, as we have new school board members tonight who may not be aware of this, this presentation is for informational purposes only and will not come back on the agenda at the next meeting.

[04:10:31] Board members, do you have any questions? All right. Seeing none, thank you, Mr. Woods. Thank you. We will continue with 13.02 Department of Business and Financial Services Annual Comprehensive Financial Report and School Activity Fund's Annual Financial Report, presented by Ms. Sharon Willoughby, our Chief Financial Officer.

[04:10:54] Good evening. I have joining me this evening Miss Lisa Wilkins to my right who is our accounting director along with Susan Casale who is our executive director of financial services they have the pleasure of Presenting our year-end fiscal year 25 reports and audit results to the school board this year and I will turn it over to them

[04:11:29] Good evening chair Chandler and school board members every year we take this opportunity to present a comprehensive overview of our financial reports for Loudoun County Public Schools. This annual review is for the fiscal year ending June 30th, 2025. It reflects our commitment to transparency, accountability, and sound financial stewardship. In board docs, there are a number of attached documents which include the financial reports and auditing

[04:12:04] letters. We will walk through the reports during this presentation. As part of our financial oversight responsibility, LCPS undergoes two separate external audits every year. The Annual Comprehensive Financial Report, also known as the ACFER, which is audited by Cherry Beckert Advisory, LLC, who conducts a thorough independent review of our district-wide financial statements. The school activity funds, along with the financial audits of our charter schools and

[04:12:43] our schools are audited by Robinson Farmer Cox Associates PLLC. Both audits are conducted in accordance with generally accepted auditing standards and government auditing standards, also known as the yellow book, ensuring that our financial practices meet the highest standards of integrity and compliance. The presentation will focus on three key areas. The first area is the annual comprehensive

financial report. This includes our district-wide funds, including the operating/general fund, capital improvement fund, non-major funds, which includes the

[04:13:21] school nutrition funds and grant fund, for example, the self-insurance fund and the OPEB trust fund. At LCPS, we follow generally accepted accounting standard principles, GAAP, to ensure consistency and accuracy in our financial reporting, which is also called the blue book.

[04:13:39] The second area is the school activity funds. These funds are managed at the individual school level, which these funds reflect the financial activities of each school's separate bank account. So this is approximately 100 bank accounts. The third area is the charter schools financial reports. We have two charter schools: Middleburg Community Charter School and Hillsboro Charter Academy. Each manages its own finances through its respective board and principal. However, the school board retains oversight responsibility for these funds. I'm very happy to report that we had a clean audit

[04:14:17] across all three areas where all information was presented fairly in all material respects. The first key area we will review is the annual comprehensive financial report, which is an annual publication that consolidates all of our financial data for fiscal year 2025.

[04:14:40] It includes financial statements such as the balance sheet, income statement, and cash flow statements for all funds, along with notes, analysis, disclosures, and statistical information. LCPS operates as a component unit of Loudoun County, which means that our financial data is incorporated into the county's ACFR.

[04:15:02] We adhere to the accounting standards established by the Government Accounting Standards Board, also known as GASB, and our financial statements are audited by an independent auditor following generally accepted government auditing standards. In BoardDocs, the audit executive summary is a separate attachment and highlights the results of the audit.

[04:15:22] We received an unmodified opinion, which represents the highest level of assurance that the auditors provide, although it is considered to be reasonable rather than absolute assurance. To put this in perspective, we managed 16 funds, which comprises approximately 1 million lines of transactions.

[04:15:40] So the auditors have to rely risk-based sampling rather than testing every transaction or else they would be auditing us all year. The audit summary reported no instances of non-compliance reflecting strong adherence to applicable laws Regulations and internal controls the report did include one uncorrected misstatement from prior year Which is the result of duplication of software contracts in fiscal year 24?

[04:16:07] This has now been corrected and recorded properly and was determined by the auditors to be immaterial so this slide shows the ending fund balance of \$52.1 million as of June 30, 2025, based on these five components listed above.

[04:16:29] First, we have the contractual obligations of \$38.8 million. These are amounts committed to encumbrances and contracts that are being carried forward for undelivered orders that will roll into the new fiscal year 2026. These are legally obligated and are not available for new purposes.

[04:16:50] Subsequent year appropriations of \$20 million were approved in fiscal year 25 for fiscal year 26 budget. So these funds are intentionally set aside to support next fiscal year's budget. Prepaid expenses of \$423,000. These are payments that are made prior to June 30th for goods or services that will be received

after June 30th. So for example, registration fees are typically have to be paid in advance for conferences that are held in July. Inventory of \$980,000. These

[04:17:25] represent tangible assets owned by LCPS at year-end. The unassigned fund balance you can see above is \$0 million. Typically the goal is that we are looking to return \$10 million or 1%. In fiscal year 24 we returned \$9.2 million. In fiscal year 25 we actually did not return any funds to the county but we transferred \$31.9 million to the self-insurance fund. Now I will

[04:17:57] turn it over to Ms. Casali for the school activity funds. Thank you, Lisa. Now we'll look at school activity funds and the audit highlights. The school activity fund financial reports are provided by our external auditing firm, Robinson Farmer Cox Associates. This shows the financial activity for each school's individual school activity fund and all activities that transpired in those accounts.

[04:18:21] We are pleased to report that 73% of the schools received zero findings. That is 72 schools out of 98 schools with zero findings. Although fewer schools had zero findings this year, the issues identified were considered immaterial, with delayed deposits being the primary finding. For example, teachers collect funds for activities, deliver them to the front office for storage in the school safe, and then deposits are made per our guidelines. Looking ahead, when we implement our new ERP

[04:18:54] system in July 2028, we will review banking options to improve this process. Despite the volume of transactions, findings represent only a small percentage of overall activity, an impressive reflection of our team's commitment to compliance and accuracy. Our philosophy remains high expectations with high support. Each year, we review audit findings and partner with schools to ensure they have the knowledge and resources to meet their financial responsibilities. During our

[04:19:30] review, we update our training to incorporate or expand our resources to support the team. The key initiatives that we have in place are two dedicated financial trainers on staff. We have internal compliance reviews. We have monthly training sessions for school and department financial technicians.

[04:19:48] An online financial resource center. We call it the repository of everything financial. We have one-on-one and on-demand training sessions for financial technicians, account managers, and principals. Our collaborative efforts will continue to enhance the efficiency of financial operations.

[04:20:06] Next, we will go through Hillsborough Charter Academy. Robinson Farmer Cox Associates has met with both charters as well as our staff in business and financial services to review the findings and recommendations for FY25.

[04:20:26] The Hillsborough Charter Academy audit covered all the charter fund operations and activities. Hillsborough received a clean audit report. The financial statements were presented fairly in all material respects. The governance letter did not have any misstatements that required a correction by management.

[04:20:41] The management memo stated all findings and recommendations from the prior year were corrected, and there were no findings recommendations for FY25. Next, Middleburg. The Middleburg Community Charter Audit covered all charter fund operations and activities as well.

[04:21:00] They received a clean audit report. The financial statements were presented fairly in all material respects. The governance letter identified one material misstatement, which was a journal entry

at the year-end, recording an expense. This has now been corrected. The management memo did not have any findings or recommendations for FY25.

[04:21:20] We continue to be a support for both Middleburg and Hillsborough in the management of their funds. We meet with the charter principal and bookkeeper on a quarterly basis. Now we go to the excellent reporting awards.

[04:21:39] Now that the annual comprehensive financial report is complete, we sent the finalized report to both the Government Finance Officers Association, GFOA, and the Association of School Business Officials ASBO, ASBO. Our participation in these two prestigious programs demonstrates our commitment to financial transparency as well as fiscal and financial integrity.

[04:22:02] These programs represent the highest form of recognition in governmental accounting and financial reporting. And achieving this recognition is a significant accomplishment for both the school system and its management. We have continued to be recognized for excellence and financial reporting by both of these organizations.

[04:22:19] We are confident that we will continue this streak to 17 years. LCPS has a solid record of producing sound financial statements and clean audits. We thank our accounting and financial services team as well as financial technicians, account managers and principals for their dedication to maintaining financial integrity.

[04:22:37] Thank you. And we'd be happy to take any questions. Thank you Ms. Consale and Ms. Wilkins and of course Ms. Willoughby for the presentation.

[04:22:54] board members are there any questions I'm sure no thank you madam chair and thank you so much for this presentation I appreciate it I just had a question since we saw sort of a decrease in schools with the 83% to 73% in terms of slide 7 you listed those high supports are those best practices for all schools each year and if they are those for schools that are not in compliance those are expectations for all schools all year during the audit process the

[04:23:32] accounting team several years ago had had developed what we call our audit matrix that identifies different risk levels of issues as well as frequency and so looking at risk level as well as frequency of findings determines what level of additional support and corrective actions are required of the school so a lower risk or lower frequency item may just require some additional training or mandatory participation in the the trainings and

[04:24:07] the monthly sessions that miss Casale was discussing a higher level risk or a more frequent finding of issues may result in the school team having to submit a written corrective action plan as well as additional require training and more support from our accounting team and our support team working more directly with the schools because we while we absolutely work to ensure that they are meeting our expectations we as stated on the slide also want to make sure that we're setting them up for success and provide a lot of support

[04:24:46] thank you for walking me through that I appreciate it mr. cardi thank you madam chair so thank you guys for this presentation I'm I can't believe Thursday we're gonna be diving into full-on into budget season so thanks for this I just I had a question because I'm not familiar enough with this but could you explain to me a little bit more about just the whole idea of comp the compensated absences that was

mentioned in here what that what that's all about so composite compensated absences was implemented in

[04:25:26] fiscal year 25. And so basically they felt that they needed to incorporate more than just a typical annual leave, which is what we accrue for, and sick leave, which we typically will pay out when someone leaves for retirees. But this is taken into a bigger aspect. And so what they've now added in was sick leave that is reported to be more likely than not to be used. And so that was the biggest component that is what they are actually accounting for with this new GASB.

[04:26:00] And just to maybe some additional clarification, GASB is the Governmental Accounting Standards Board that is one of many resources that we must follow in terms of how we prepare financial statements.

[04:26:16] They typically give guidance at this point. It almost seems every year there's something new that they are rolling out, and typically they give us a couple years heads up notice because they are usually significant. The compensated absences change was a significant change for LCPS as Ms. Wilkins identified. We typically had reported a certain level of leave and like as a liability knowing that this is something we would have to pay out for eligible employees related to our policies and the compensated absences

[04:26:50] Gatsby statement just broadened that significantly and required a significant amount of analysis and change to our financial statements so is this money that we had budgeted for and we just had to reallocate or is this money that we're having to find what can you explain that a little bit sure it's more of a balance sheet item than an income statement item so we do budget for you sick leave to occur during the year, but this is more of a long-term look and projection related

[04:27:29] to, GASB is usually related to the financial statements and the financial statements being transparent and giving a level of confidence to the public related to the financial stability and fairness in reporting that you provide. What's a little different when it comes from the private sector than the public sector, the private sector is usually wanting to make sure that financial statements are fairly represented and transparent because for stakeholders, for the public who may be participating in buying stocks or bonds, all those areas.

[04:28:04] In the government, it's a little different because, and specifically for LCPS, because we also don't issue debt, so we don't have the burden of having to worry about carrying a bond rating. But because since we are a component unit of the county, Our financial statements are audited, of course, and we do take pride in having strong financial statements, having strong audit results that supports the county's own process and audit, so that combined we contribute to their solid bond ratings.

[04:28:43] Mr. Pepper. We return really quickly to the school activity funds and the report of audit findings and recommendations. I noticed that a lot of what you said was in cash handling. Has the school system considered moving away from accepting cash at school sites to perhaps make our financial dealings a little bit more secure?

[04:29:08] It is something that we have considered, and I think you will find when we talk about the budget actually starting on Thursday, as Ms. Riccardi mentioned, we'll actually dive into this a little bit more regarding some background of how LCPS has managed electronic payments that would maybe give some light in terms of why we have not moved to a purely cashless system.

[04:29:34] We're also sensitive to the fact that while it is definitely a predominant method of payment, we still want to make sure that we still give opportunities for all families to pay in a manner that is most reasonable for them, as well as to avoid additional credit card fees, for example.

[04:29:55] So at this point, it is one factor that we are looking at, along with other factors, especially as we move through our new ERP process. We are wanting to make sure that we are reducing risks and trying to make things as easy as possible. Thank you so much for the presentation.

[04:30:20] And with that, we will move on to 13.03, Finance and Operations Committee Revision of Policy 4170, Insurance Management. Presented tonight by school board member Dena Griffiths, Ms. Sharon Willoughby, Chief Financial Officer, and Andrea Filiol, Director of Procurement and Risk Management.

[04:30:41] Thank you, Madam Chair. Actually, if we could bring you back, Sharon. I thought we'd just have you stay. This meeting was December 9th, and if you could help out, provide details on these five items that we did go over.

[04:31:00] the Finance and Operations Committee if you could did you want to come back up or you'll speak from over there I can quickly go through these hopefully okay so the first policy related to insurance management this policy was implemented to safeguard all our property and interest and interest related to insurance as well as for our employees the last revision was in November of 2021, and it was brought forward as part of our five-year cycle review. There are a few edits

[04:31:35] that were redlined that came out of committee. One was on line nine on the redline version was to add cybersecurity as another example of the type of insurance coverage that LCPS would provide. Additionally, a red line edit was made related to the coverage of school board members and what they are eligible for, but wanting to specify that they are excluded from workers' compensation because school board members are in a unique position. While they receive compensation from LCPS, they are not employees of the district, so they're not eligible for

[04:32:15] workers' comp. And then the last item was just providing some additional clarification related to the chief financial officer's designee. I don't know if anybody has any questions on that or what she just went over.

[04:32:35] Thank you. School board members, any questions? What is our interest in moving this along to the consent agenda at the next meeting? Thumbs up, please. All right. That will move on to the consent agenda. Thank you so much.

[04:32:50] Our next item is 13.04, Finance and Operations Committee, a new policy, 4190, other post-employment benefits funding, which will be presented by Mrs. Griffiths. - Same thing here. This was discussed in our meeting on December 9th, and I'm just hoping we could provide, or have Ms. Willoughby provide details for the board and for the people of Loudoun County.

[04:33:17] Thank you. - Thank you. School board members, are there any questions? - Mr. Pepper. - So my question is on OPEB on 4190. In terms of the makeup of the OPEB board, particularly lines 43 to 48 says that the board includes a superintendent or designee chair of the board of supervisors finance government services operations chair of the school boards finance operations county treasurer and

[04:33:51] a citizen member my question is really how is that citizen member determined on this board the the establishment of the OPEB Finance Board it is a joint committee between the county and LCPS. I

think I heard you describe the members is a board member from the county, a board member from the schools, the chair of the county's finance government

[04:34:28] services operations committee, and then our chair of our finance committee, and then the superintendent's designee, which historically has been the chief financial officer. And then the the citizen member has been selected by the other members of the board in determining who the citizen member is. And that citizen member I can share currently in my understanding in past practice has been someone who has a financial investment background. Does that current member

[04:35:04] have any connection to the LCPS retiree health insurance or other post-employment benefits or is it just somebody who was selected for their background in finance? Since this is the OPEB finance board and they are tasked with the responsible management of the assets of the plan and helping to derive the investment strategy, this board has no oversight of the retiree or the OPEB benefits of either the county or the schools. So the background of the current

[04:35:40] citizen member is is financial investment i believe he actually also has some medical background but in terms of i think you may be implying like if there's any more direct connection between either organization there's not to my knowledge okay and then um just one one more follow-up question for you miss will be apologize um is is there a need that you believe or maybe even other members of the board believe that we establish a policy as to how this citizen member

[04:36:14] is selected for this board simply because the other positions are spelled out and we really are almost with this policy leaving it who could be anyone the board the the opev finance board has its own rules and i'm not sure if by putting in our policy we could drive who sits or the qualifications. I think perhaps a more appropriate pathway could be sharing that information with

[04:36:53] the, with actually who's sitting next to you. You know, Ms. Griffiths, who is the chair of the finance and operations committee, will be joining me on those OPEF finance boards. And that's something we could bring up in terms of discussion and see if there's interest with other board members in terms of outlining. To be fully transparent, there may be something written somewhere related to the qualifications of a citizen member, um, I'm just not aware of that off the top of my head. Thank you. Thank you. Madam chair, if I might provide further clarity,

[04:37:27] um, Virginia code under section 15.2, 1547 talks about the creation of such a board and it does provide language that would be helpful for the board's consideration to Mr. Pepper's, uh, inquiry. It specifically says, as for that citizen, a demonstrated experience in cash management and in investments with proven integrity and business ability.

[04:37:52] So the board could consider tracking that language and adding that into this policy. Thank you, Mr. Allen. Ms. Riccardi, and then we'll have Mrs. Griffiths. I know I'll be joining on the F&O committee, so I've got kind of a list of things.

[04:38:09] I think one of the things just generally with these new policies and existing policies, as well, is making sure that we have some way of really kind of enforcing them. So I actually have a bunch of questions, but I'm not going to ask them tonight right now. But I would like to pose them.

[04:38:27] Ms. Willoughby, I think I'll send them to you, and then we can figure out the right people that can answer those questions. And also I'll send them to both of you for committee work. But I think part of it is I want to get clarity, but also I think this I think there's some places We can tighten up some of the

language within this policy. So I'll forward that on to you guys. Thanks Thank you, Mrs. Griffiths And for transparency, we know who everybody else is on the board. Are you able to tell us who this person is?

[04:38:57] He would put me on the spot. I'm sorry. I'm drawing a blank. I can picture him. I can by all means relay that person's name back to the board. And maybe we can take a look at him, look at this person ahead of time. Mrs. Griffiths, I have that answer readily available.

[04:39:13] It's on the Board of Supervisors website. His name is Jeffrey Magid, M-A-G-E-D, and his term started October 7th, 2025 and concludes October 6th, 2027. Thank you. Mrs. Chernoff.

[04:39:32] Thank you, Madam Chair. Just a follow-up. I think I'm sort of following the line of questions from Mr. Pepper as well because several retirees have reached out. As a result, we've had a very fulsome conversation with our retirees over the last year and very grateful for the committee and an opportunity to be a part of that special committee that did talk about OPEB. So I think there's a little bit of confusion, I think in my inbox at least, about how that feedback from our actual retirees who are enrolled in these programs have a direct line of feedback and whether or not this policy was written as a response to that committee and I think the answer is

[04:40:12] no so if you could just clarify that for our constituents that they understand sort of what the separation is between the role of this committee as well as where the feedback for what directly impacts them might have a better place thank you yes I've seen and received some additional questions as well so I appreciate the opportunity to provide the clarification this policy had been in the works for a while the county already has a policy in place relating to the funding and I think that is the key word here is that it's not about the OPEB benefit it's about the funding

[04:40:50] of that benefit and this policy is intended to ensure that we have the financial resources in the future to meet the benefits of the retirees down the road and you know wanting to maintain that you know fiscal integrity and so the funding policy itself while it's brand new it's listing you know definitions and it's talking about guidelines of how the fund is funded you know currently you know funds are being deposited from lcps and also a significant funding each year of

[04:41:26] 12 million dollars is appropriated from the county directly into our opeb fund there's also additional language in here as it relates to funding guidelines because currently right now this is what I would almost call like a deposit only account. The only thing that is happening in terms of the financial activity in our OPEB fund is you see deposits going in and then you see the investment earnings that are occurring during the year. At some point once we reach a level of 70 percent of our future funded liability, meaning we have enough cash in the fund to pay for the

[04:42:06] 70 percent value of that future retiree benefit. This fund could turn into, where it's not deposit only and just holding and accumulating all the funds, we could begin to make withdrawals to pay for that retiree benefit. Currently today, any expenses related to retiree benefits are on a pay as you go, meaning the school operating fund is paying for those expenses as they come in.

[04:42:33] Once we hit that 70% threshold, we could begin to use the money in this fund to begin to pay for those bills. And subsequently, the county could reduce its transfer into the fund because now it's more financially stable. There's language in the policy as well that should that threshold fall below 70 percent that we would revisit the strategy of withdrawing and wanting to make sure that we have a minimum. So this really is set up to help provide additional transparency into the

[04:43:09] funding and our commitment to making sure we have those funds available to support that retiree benefit that is covered in other policies that we have. Sure enough. Thank you Ms. Willoughby I really appreciate that and while it may have not been a direct result of the committee I think it does help to move us toward addressing some of the concerns that were brought up by our retirees through that process because they were asking for more transparency more foresight on the planning making sure that the funds are more secure so that they're not feeling in limbo so I

[04:43:44] do appreciate this step towards this new policy whatever its origin and I'm grateful for the conversation on their behalf thank you miss Riccardi thank Madam Chair just as a kind of a follow-up to that and I don't see on this list here anywhere do we have any retirees Planned to be added to That committee at all and then I'm just kind of secondly to that is there a communications plan For you the current retirees or future soon to be retirees about this

[04:44:19] So again the structure of the OPEB finance board that is a joint committee and that also that Mr. Allen mentioned that there's, you know, code language that also establishes the requirement of this joint committee. The structure of that board is managed by the members of that board.

[04:44:37] So there is no discussion at this time of adding retirees from LCPS or the county to this board. And I think the reason being that, again, this is more about the investment strategy and funding, not necessarily the benefit structures or the benefits that either organization is providing retirees. Thank you. All right, school board members, looking for a little direction in terms

[04:45:09] of the next step. Any, what, is there any desire to put it on the consent agenda? Nope. Okay, thank you. I just had a check. Thank you very much. We will move on to our next policy tonight. This is policy or excuse me item 1305 finance and operations committee revision of 4310 purchasing authority which will also be presented by mrs. griffiths thank you madam chair again these were these five items were discussed at the december 9th meeting and we chose to bring them back to

[04:45:48] the board as information items so if you don't mind miss willoughby discussing purchasing authority policy 4310 thank you policy 4310 purchasing authority was originally implemented to define the role of the purchasing agent and i'll emphasize that's a capital p and a capital a and this is to be compliant with state and federal requirements as well the last revision was made in november of 2021 so where it's being brought forward as part of the five-year cycle review

[04:46:25] The redlining in here is minimal and really is just being more specific and providing additional clarification that any contact between any offers or bidders or vendors should be between the procurement and risk management services employees and or support services.

[04:46:49] And those two areas are specifically called out because in the original language, the unchanged language, the purchasing agent for the board is the procurement director as well as the chief operations officer for design and construction services.

[04:47:06] So, let me just restate that. So, the Chief Operations Officer has oversight and responsibility of the design and construction services related to capital projects, and the procurement director basically has everything else related to LCPS purchasing authority.

[04:47:24] Thank you. Ms. Chernoff. Thank you, Madam Chair. I guess my question sort of has to do with how, I mean, I hear what you're saying in terms of purchasing authority with construction and that side and then also procurement.

[04:47:44] but I guess I'm kind of wondering if schools also have that purchasing authority and so if you could kind of differentiate between purchasing authority and signing authority and then how that accountability is maintained because that's a lot of cooks in the kitchen in terms of a hundred different schools maybe having those abilities and I just want to if it's the procurement office and the construction side that are ultimately accountable how are we making sure that these policies create that accountability and there aren't any gaps there i would look at so there are a handful of procurement

[04:48:23] policies in section in the 400 the 4000 section in our policies and regulations and so it makes a little difficult just looking at one because you almost have to look at all of them combined to see how we provide oversight related to purchasing for lcp's to make sure we are compliant with the Virginia Code, the VPPA, which is the Virginia Public Procurement Act.

[04:48:50] I look at 4310, the purchasing authority, as being that umbrella to procurement for the division, where we must designate the purchasing agent, again, capital P, capital A, that designated point person to provide the oversight related to procurement for the division.

[04:49:09] And so in the policy on lines 11 through 14, it highlights how all personnel in the division who desire to purchase equipment and supplies shall follow established procurement procedures. Those procedures have been created from the procurement office and approved by the school board and are covered in other policies that we have currently existing.

[04:49:36] There can be confusion between purchasing authority and signing authority. And what I can highlight is that the purchasing authority, again, is really that authority and oversight to source materials and services for the division.

[04:49:53] We are currently reviewing some of our other policies to more clearly define who is authorized to sign contracts on behalf of the school board, along with the applicable monetary thresholds. and we do plan on bringing those to the fno committee in the near future because there has been a lot of questions about signing authority um and we just want to make sure like this is an opportunity for us to tighten up in that area and again we will be bringing something forward here soon to the committee and ultimately the school board on the signing side thank you for

[04:50:31] that clarification i also i'm just that's just making me wonder if maybe since we're kind of looking at it as an umbrella and then we have all these other pieces that you guys are gonna also tackle in F&O. It just sort of makes me wonder if they should be a package and sort of be looked at. I mean if we approve one and then we approve the pieces underneath and it changes the umbrella are we gonna have to work backwards I guess. So in terms of next steps I'm just trying to think if it makes more practical sense for us as a board in terms of looking at procurement overall which it feels like we're kind of addressing that whole topic which is a big one in terms of the amount of purchasing that happens in

[04:51:09] this division and the RFPs and the different things that go out so just kind of food for thought for my colleagues as I'm sort of hearing that we're gonna be going you all are gonna be going through that process and F&O if it makes more sense to sort of pause do them as a group and make sure that we don't have to you know go back and redo work ahead but that's not really a question it's more of a statement so it's something that I'm thinking about for next time is possibly you know pausing this and and moving forward I guess my question with that would that give you heartburn in terms of delaying if we were to consider doing them as a package deal versus moving forward with

[04:51:45] this one first I don't have any heartburn of pausing on this one and then pairing it with the policy that were or whatever the if we're creating a new policy or for wanting to revise an existing policy related to the signing authority as you'll see that the next two on the agenda are also procurement so I just want to be to set expectations to not necessarily try to bring all the procurement policies but I think it would be beneficial and I would not have any concern if if this one was paused or sent back

[04:52:24] to committee or whatever the school board should desire and pair it up whenever we bring the the signing authority forward okay i appreciate that thank you i guess i have a point of information then um it's mr cody yeah madam chair um are we able then to take these four and send them from here back to committee versus having to go to action and then moving it back and so that means

[04:52:57] we're not gonna look at them till february the appropriate committee for further review um have it continue as an information item for a future meeting or place it on the agenda for action next time or place it on the consent agenda. And at this time, if we wanted Mr. Allen to group these four policies together and send them back to committee, does that require a motion or is it

[04:53:30] the will of the chair? Thank you, Madam Chair. Typically, and you might just for clarity of the record go through each one and do the temperature check and if the majority of the board sends is leaning towards sending it back to committee then that's how the approach that will the policy will take or if there's another approach of the the four options that you chose that has a majority of the board it will proceed in that fashion but a formal vote since this is an information item does not need to be taken thank you for that clarification so we can do a temperature check

[04:54:07] um we did earlier decide that um 4170 would go on the consent agenda could i that still stands board members okay so for our consideration at this time we would move new policy 4190 revision of policy 4340 revision of policy 4350 so that's three and four wait uh thank you for

[04:54:42] that clarification, Mrs. Griffiths, and 4310 back to the F&O committee. Is there, Mrs. Griffith, would you like to? Thank you, Madam Chair. I think that would be the thing to do. We have a new committee. This was all looked at in the previous, and I would certainly love to go over it with the new committee members, so I think sending it back to committee is a good idea. Thank you for that clarification is there any further discussion no okay to restate our this our action the following

[04:55:20] four policies will be given the just before we take a temperature check to make sure that we're fully on the same page 4190 4310 4340 and 4350 please give me a thumbs up if you would like that to move to F&O oh sure Mrs. Chernoff what's your clarifying question I just wanted to double check with miss willoughby because i think what you said earlier was that the procurement ones are separate from the signing authority so i think the one that's coming up for review for signing

[04:55:54] authority is 4370 if i'm correct so that would be the one we would group so it would really just be this one policy that we're looking at that we're talking about directly now in terms of authority that would go is that correct that would be my preference because also what maybe not all school board members are aware there are several other procurement policies that are about to come through F&O committee like I said there are there are there probably the most number that we have is in policy wise is related to procurement and so again just trying to set expectations of the

[04:56:32] board and the committee to try to look at all of them in one meeting I don't think is feasible and I would also have some concern with 4340 and 4350 which I believe to be maybe um I maybe a little

more straightforward that we could get important changes made to policies and in place now versus delaying those yes so just to clarify for you madam chair it would be 4310 purchasing authority that is item 13.05 that I would suggest go back to committee and be reviewed in conjunction with the other signing authority policies such as 4370 is that an accurate

[04:57:12] account of what you just summarized yes thank you you're welcome thank you for that clarifying comment that is a little bit different than what has been discussed by other school board members so could you please mr. pepper weigh in certainly the only question I have is really for miss Willoughby and I know we had just said that 4310 acts as kind of an umbrella to other procurement policies my concern is that 4340 and 4350 are also procurement policies so therefore if we make changes to 4310 would that mean we would then need to

[04:57:46] revisit 4340 and 4350 i do not believe so i think 40 i think that umbrella policy of 4310 is more a very overarching of designating the responsible parties and i don't i don't envision a scenario where that list would expand beyond our procurement director and our chief operations officer okay thank you for that clarification school board members um let's see would you school board

[04:58:23] members would you like to go through each information item and hear Ms. Willoughby's overview and take them one by one to inform next steps on policy? Okay. Ms. Willoughby if you would please. 4340. Next is procurement procedures is what it is currently listed as. This was last revised in May of 2022 to align with BPPA. The policy was implemented initially to identify the

[04:58:58] mandatory contract terms and conditions which have been added to the to regulation 4340 contract terms and conditions the policy itself then has been repurposed to provide the items exempt from the vppa so when you look at the red line version the title has been revised to procurement Procurement Procedure Exemptions. You're going to see a lot of red, new red sections. A, B, and

[04:59:30] C really covers those exemptions. And so for example, there's statutory exemptions. So listed is like legal services. Per VPPA, we do not have to do a solicitation for legal services as an example. Another example is purchase of textbooks that are already approved and on the Virginia Board of Education's list. So again, we don't have to go out and do a solicitation for textbooks if we are procuring those items off of their approved list. There's also some administrative exemptions such as advertising and bank service charges. And then there's a section related to

[05:00:08] non-procurement transactions. After that section, you'll see a lot of redlining related to certification regarding sex offenses this is required language and it's not that we are striking it out is for striking out and moving it to our regulation and the thought there is that by putting in a regulation if there were any changes at the state level we could be more reactive and make those required changes in the regulation as most school board members know and maybe some of the new newer school board members may not be fully aware regulations don't go through the school board and policies do and policies can take up about you know two months

[05:00:47] and so again it was really wanting to make sure that this important section that we could react quickly by moving it to our regulation thank you any follow-up questions on this item at this time all right would you please move on to the next procurement policy the last one that I have this evening is Policy 4350 Vendor Relations. This was last revised in March of 2022, and it was implemented to establish guidelines for vendor relationships. The red line section here,

[05:01:24] the more material items is under Section B, where we are more specific in terms of the acceptance of gifts. And I'll mention that there's also, we added cross-reference to Policy 2160 Conflicts of interest. So we are, you know, mirroring information there. The IRS doesn't give specific guidance. It just cites a de minimis amount. And so our internal practice has been guidance anytime this question came up. Our internal guidance and practice has been to not accept anything that has a value over 20. And so we are actually just now codifying that and

[05:02:02] outlining for employees to not accept any gifts over \$20, and also putting language in here for vendors and bidders or offerors to not offer a gift more than \$20 should they jeopardize their response to a solicitation. Then we added a Section D, Ethics in Public Contracting, with an organization our size and the volume of procurement that we do. It definitely happens where there could be a conflict of interest, perhaps an employee has a side business or an

[05:02:38] employee has a spouse who has a business who is responding to a solicitation and there are certain disclosures that must be made. And so we are just lifting or we're just being transparent in terms of those requirements for vendors as well as for our employees. And so that is the reason of adding that section of the ethics and public contracting. Thank you for that clarity. Any questions on this specific policy at this time board members okay let's go back up we will address 13.05

[05:03:13] revision of policy 4310 purchasing authority can you show me based on a thumbs up or a thumbs down if you would like to move this particular policy back to F&O just 4310 right policy 4310 will move back to F&O for further consideration by that committee now let's move on to 13.06 revision of policy 4340 procurement procedures would the school board like to move this policy back to F&O or keep it on the agenda let's start with the question would you like to move it back to F&O

[05:03:51] please let me know what your thoughts are based on a thumbs up or a thumbs down okay so this item we'll stay on the agenda for the next meeting and we'll come back as an action item thank you we will also finally move on to 13.07 let's do the same thing for policy 4350 vendor relations

[05:04:26] school board members please let me know if you would like to send this back to fno or move it to action on the next agenda with a thumbs up for fno all right thank you very much that item will stay on the agenda and will return to the next meeting as an action item thank you so much for that conversation which was very impactful now we will move on to item 13.08 this is an item out of

[05:05:03] legislative audit and policy committee revisions to policy 2230 legal counsel tonight this item will be presented by vice chair and donahue thank you miss donahue please unmute miss donahue we aren't able to hear you at all. We're going to see if we can make some adjustments on the technical

[05:05:40] side. Thanks for your patience.

[05:07:18] Team is working to resolve a technical issue.

[05:07:47] So it might be a

[05:07:48] minute or two. Thank you for the update.

[05:08:40] Check one. Check two. It's a whole suite.

[05:09:27] The team tested and the audio is working. So it appears the issue is on her side. So they're reaching out to provide technical support. We'll probably have her leave the meeting and rejoin and see if that resolves audio issues. Okay. In the interest of time and efficiency, why don't we move away from the

Legislative Audit and Policy Committee policies and go to item 13.11, Specialized Program Centers and Committee Middleburg Community Charter School Amendment to Charter Agreement, which will be presented by Dr. Sumerah Rasheed. Thank you, Chair Chandler. When Hillsborough Charter Academy,

[05:10:04] their agreement was renewed, there was some language that was placed in it that dealt with disciplinary actions for students that engaged in like the wrong behavior so now that they have that language implemented in their agreement MCCC Middleborough Community Charter School would like to implement that same language so that there can be consistency I just want to turn it over to dr. Ashley Ellis in case I missed anything no dr. Rasheed that you got that right it's pretty straightforward MCCC revisions are in alignment with

[05:10:41] what already exists with Hillsboro Community Charter thank you I would like to start with a question dr. Ellis I'm hoping that you can help us better understand how these the the language that's been included in the charter agreements for both of the charter schools how it comparatively works with what is standard for a home school in a neighborhood and how it works compared to some of our specialized programs where students may have applied to

[05:11:16] participate I'd just like to understand better how these how this language is appropriately applied and where it's different great thank you for that question so my understanding is that it is in alignment with both the language around special permission and also our special programs and academies thank you so that is consistent with not only students who are going to different schools based on special permission

[05:11:51] but all of our special programs would also be treated the same way yes such as the health and medical science program or IB an IB program if you're not already zoned for that school and then with our neighborhood schools there is a policy that exists that allows for certain types of decisions to be made that can cause students to be moved into other scenarios yes ma'am okay thank you school board members are there any questions miss Riccardi I just was as I was going through and reading this agreement I noticed this was from 2017 is that the newest agreement that we

[05:12:29] have with the charter school? It is the current agreement. Yes. Can I have a minute to confirm that? I'm sorry.

[05:13:00] The current agreement is 2022. Okay. So is it different than the one that was posted or did I miss it? Maybe I missed. I just want to make sure that language is the same in both. No, I appreciate you saying that. Um, let me check with the team to make sure the correct one was posted in board docs. Cause I do see what you're referring to. It clearly says 2017 at the

[05:13:39] top of the first page. Okay. I just really want to make sure those sections of the document are the same and they may be carried over. Thank you. I will check on that. Any other further questions? Special permission. Am I correct that those policies are a bit more detailed about the procedures that are in place than this more general language of the charter schools or is it identical language? So I may ask Mr. Slevin to jump in here regarding special programs we do have pretty detailed guidance for schools regarding this

[05:14:17] topic for our own home schools so this language is is not as detailed as that guidance thank you mr. pepper so as I read the red line um it was kind of piggybacking off of what mr. defense and said it says

that they reserve the right to consult with the LCPS office of school administration do we know that consultation would look like so our director of school administration should be here yes she's

[05:14:55] here yay um so she can answer that question directly um but it is often a starts with a phone call and guidance and sometimes that's enough and the principal can can go forth and make that decision um other times more consultation is needed and miss scanlon i don't know if you would add anything to that um it could it could you please repeat the question for me okay i'm going to repeat it then i'm also going to ask a follow-up i just want to know it so the policy says that the charter school reserves the right to consult with lcps office of school administration to consider return of students i'm curious as to what the consultation process would be

[05:15:33] and if based on this really the second part of the question is could we as lcps hold them to a similar process like that of our academies or other programs. So I'm going to do my best with this one. Um, and I will defer as well to division council if there is additional information to add, but student discipline, um, processes are the purview of a school principal, the division superintendent, the division superintendent's designee, um, which is my office, um, and the

[05:16:10] school board in certain circumstances. So when there is a disciplinary incident where a school principal, any school principal, wishes to have consultation, then that principal will call our office and we are happy to consult. If there is a matter that is referred to the Office of School administration then in all cases a school principal makes a recommendation there is dialogue surrounding that disciplinary recommendation that recommendation is

[05:16:45] considered it is discussed and then ultimately my hearing officer myself acting as the division superintendent's designee makes a final determination and that may be appealed to the school board, but otherwise that is the final determination. Thank you. Yes, Dr. Ellis. Thank you, Chair. I'm just following up on Ms. Riccardi's question and it does look like the wrong version

[05:17:24] was uploaded into board docs. We will get the correct version uploaded. And so because of that, my recommendation would be to not put this on consent. So you can see the real one and I couldn't begin to go through the um changes line by line they are not significant from year to year um but there may be changes that we would want you to have access to so we'll get that changed thanks for checking that thank you thank you for that clarification um miss donahue i understand

[05:17:55] you have a question we're still not hearing you uh hello madam chair hello vice chair donahue how are you okay i'm i'm okay thank you for your patience uh apologies for whatever the technical issue was i just had um this is more of a comment uh i didn't have some concern with this proposed

[05:18:31] language um i understand that we are looking to make it consistent with language that's in the Hillbrook charter agreement, but I did, following up on, I believe it was Mr. Benson's comment before, or his question before, about how detailed other policies are in LTPS about rescinding or removing students from certain schools or programs, I just wanted to also point out that since we just

[05:19:03] amended policy 8155 on school assignment, part of that revision included making decisions to rescind a student, grant a special permission, has to go through a required process, and is also now appealable to the board. And I have some concerns with comparing how that process would work with how it might work at the charter schools based on the language this state presents.

[05:19:37] Thank you. Thank you. Any further questions from the board? All right. Given the conversation, this item will come back for action at our next school board meeting. And we will go back up to our legislative audit and policy committee policies.

[05:19:55] So next up is 13.08 revisions to policy 2330 legal counsel presented by Vice Chair Donohue. Thank you very much. Madam Chair, policy 2230 on legal counsel.

[05:20:12] This policy came before the Legislation Audit and Policy Committee as it is coming up for its five-year review. It was last reviewed in 2021. It was presented as an information item to the committee on November 18th, was sent out for feedback, and then returned to the committee for action on December 9th.

[05:20:33] Substantial changes were made to this policy from its previous versions that lay out in more specific detail the scope of the responsibilities of Division Council. When this matter was sent out for feedback, one suggestion was received back from NSAC, which suggestion has been incorporated into the red line that is posted on board docs.

[05:20:59] And there were no other suggestions or public feedback. The recommendation from the committee is that the board support the proposed changes and approve the revised policy at the next full board meeting, and I would defer to Dr. Bergen for if I have overlooked any important background information.

[05:21:20] Thank you, Vice Chair Donahue. Dr. Bergen, I see you're saying there's no need. No, that was a fulsome report on the changes. Thank you so much, Dr. Bergen. Board members, are there any questions? All right, seeing no questions, would there be any appetite to send this to the consent agenda?

[05:21:45] All right, thank you so much. With that, we will go on to revisions to Policy 2540, our policy manual, presented again by Vice Chair Donahue.

[05:22:01] Thank you, Madam Chair. Policy 2540, entitled Policy Manual, also came before the committee for its upcoming five-year review as it was last reviewed in 2021. It also was presented as an information item to the committee on November 18th, was sent out for feedback, and then came before the committee again for action on December 9th.

[05:22:27] There are minimal changes proposed for the revisions in this policy, and I believe there was no feedback received. The committee recommendation is that the board support the proposed changes and approve the revised policy at the next full board meeting.

[05:22:47] And again, I will defer to Dr. Bergen if I have overlooked any important background information. Thank you, Vice Chair Donohue. And I'll be happy to confirm for the audience that Dr. Bergen is suggesting it's not necessary to add any further information. School board members, do we have any questions?

[05:23:06] Okay. Seeing no questions, is there an appetite to send this to consent? all right thank you school board members um we will move on to our last legislative audit and policy committee policy this is a new policy 6330 distribution of information and posting within schools on school grounds or during school sponsored events this policy will be presented by vice chair and donahue thank you madam chair uh as you stated this is policy 6330 entitled distribution of information and posting within schools on school grounds or during school

[05:23:44] sponsored events. This is an entirely new policy which has been proposed by staff to take the place of the previous policy, number 8-65, which is titled Felicitation, Distribution, and Posting. That policy, 8-65, was first adopted in 2015. The staff originally proposed this new policy, 2330, in 2023, and it came out of the Finance and Operations Committee. F&O sent the new policy to the full board, and it was an information item at the January 30th, 2024 meeting, which,

[05:24:23] as some of you will remember, was our second meeting of the entirely new board when it turned over in January 2024. Prior to sending the proposed new policy to the full board, FNO had sent the proposed draft out for public feedback and received numerous and significant feedback and suggestions on the policy. The full board chose to send the draft new policy back to F&O for additional work and discussion, and it was an information item again in F&O in March of 2024.

[05:25:04] Somehow it ended up in LA&P, with further changes proposed by staff, was presented as an information item to the Legislation Audit Policy Committee on November 18, 2025. And it returned as an action item on December 9 of 2025. It had been sent out for feedback. In the meantime, there was minimal feedback received that I would note and probably should have noted for the other two policies that

[05:25:37] went out for feedback in late November, right before Thanksgiving, and then returned to LA&T in December that I believe not all of the advisory councils were able to meet and vote on feedback in such a short time span. So the recommendation of the committee is that the board support the new policy, support the deletion of prior policy 8-65, approve the new policy, and the deletion of 8-65 at the next full board meeting. In just one moment, I will again ask Dr. Bergen if I have

[05:26:16] overlooked any important background information, but first I wanted to speak to the somewhat confusing breadline. The version that staff presented at the L.A. and P. meeting struck out the provision that allows distribution of political or campaign material on certain non-election days on LCPS property during LCPS activities.

[05:26:47] So the version that staff presented to the L.A.P. committee would have provided that such distribution could only occur on election days and on no other, on no non-election days.

[05:27:04] A majority of the committee approved a revision that now appears at lines 85 to 96 of the red line that was posted on board docs. And those lines add back a limited opportunity for distribution on specific certain non-election days.

[05:27:23] But the original version, again, that was submitted to the committee by staff crossed out lines 71 to 83 and did not include lines 85 to 96.

[05:27:41] So with that, I will defer to Dr. Bergen for any other important background information. Dr. Bergen. That was a terrific summary from Vice Chair Donahue. Very accurate on all the dates. And this has been discussed at great length among staff, legal counsel, and the school board members individually and particularly through LANP.

[05:28:07] I would restate that it is a recommendation of staff, or was, coming in the door to LANP that new paragraph 2 and 6330 at line 56 would prohibit the distribution of materials on non-school days.

[05:28:24] The reasoning being, it has been permitted up until the contemplation of this new policy under 865, but we consistently receive complaints from parents in schools that despite the fact that it's in policy and individuals of both political parties are notified of the provision that you cannot essentially

canvass it back to school nights and at open houses, that it does occur regularly as opposed to individuals complying with the requirements and policies.

[05:28:56] to remain stationary and 40 feet from a door. So therefore, it was the recommendation of staff that we prohibit the distribution of materials per new paragraph two at line 56. And as Mrs. Donoghue summarized, there was great discussion at LAMP about putting in the provision back at line 85, new paragraph three.

[05:29:20] So that's how it sits before the board tonight. So thank you. Happy to answer any more clarifying questions. Thank you. School board members. I'll just point out that we are approaching 10 o'clock. We still have quite a crowd for our discussion item tonight that said Do you have any questions on this policy? Dr. Rasheed? I thank you chair. I just saw like, you know, MSAC MSAC's comments were included into this poll into the red line copy I just wanted to confirm that school board members. I miss are there any further questions miss recording?

[05:30:00] I see a bunch of different versions of it here again this is kind of a newbie school board thing I apologize but I'm just trying to make sure I'm on the same page with the versions that we're looking at because there's a bunch of them in here so the most recent version of it is the 1216 yeah the one that's being discussed is the distribution of materials posting with schools redline 12 16 25 okay there's a clean copy of that but the

[05:30:36] redline version shows the conversation yeah I appreciate it thank you and so right now we're suggesting that that's right i'll take care of it thank you thank you um dr rasheed yes i just wanted to ensure that the msac recommendations were included and i'm assuming they are but i'm looking into detail i couldn't really find i know there's some clauses listed so i just wanted to double check on that um are there any further questions oh mrs griffiths

[05:31:12] thank you madam chair um while it says 12 12 16 um it does say another date it says february 6 2024 on it as well so there's a little confusion there for me and i think that might have been what miss ricardi that's the current version of the policy prior to the board considering it during this round okay thank you mr pepper my question just has to do with actually section a1 in the the lines 6 to 20 looks like 20 or 21 in those groups that are allowed to post or should be

[05:31:47] materials schools school affiliated groups the one group I don't see in there is the Loudon Education Association and I'm curious as to how they would fall in the permissibility policy for example a the LEA goes into a building and just puts up a flyer and the teachers allows it says join the LEA. So how would they fit into this policy? I think Mr. Pepper, Ms.

[05:32:15] Bolin can certainly respond in more detail if needed, but in short, access to the buildings and posting in the buildings will be covered under the collective bargaining agreement. That's all I needed to know. Thank you, Dr. Spence. Ms. Chernoff. Thank you, Madam Chair. As a member of the LAMP committee formally that reviewed this, I just, I wanted to make sure, I mean, I know we're running up against the clock and I understand that. This, I think this is an important topic that garners discussion on the full board so I don't know what the plan is if we're going to plan to discuss it again or just move it to action but I felt like there were components of this that felt rushed to

[05:32:55] me in committee and I expressed that especially in terms of the feedback that this might need from the public so I have said this in committee and I will say it again I am torn on this on a couple of

levels it is very clear from staff and in fact I have actually personally gotten text from principals during back-to-school events asking me can I reach out to dr. Spence and can they get some help at the school level because people were being bad actors and not following the appropriate policy and that falls then on the building administration I believe in most cases and they're there to greet their

[05:33:33] families and they're there to help welcome kids into the school for the school year. And so I definitely understand that this, for me, this is really a management piece and who's going to enforce it. And so while I appreciate the stricter guidelines in Ms. Donahue's amendment that has been added at line 85, I also am wondering if staff could chime in, and this would be Dr. Bergen, and I see that Ms. Mitchell is not present, but maybe Ms. Allen, you could speak to sometimes more restriction in my mind means more oversight is needed also. So while I

[05:34:11] understand it is more manageable in terms of it being away from the building, I also think that that could also mean they're even then principals might have to be further away from their building to manage it. So if you could just speak to that a little bit from a staff perspective and then I do have one follow-up. Thank you for that question Mr. Chernoff. The language in the policy as it sits before you tonight in the red line version new paragraph three line 85 is almost verbatim the same language that exists today in 865 stationary 40 feet from the door uh and that's

[05:34:49] what we've been receiving complaints on so i concur with your comments that it is a management issue and it pulls the administration away from the main function which is to greet their parents and to to be the host of a back to school night or an open house to go outside to have conversations with individuals who've been forewarned and asked not to do what they are then doing.

[05:35:11] Thank you, Dr. Bergen. And then for me on the flip side of this is, you know, I was once a candidate and I stood out and met lots of parents at back to school night. And it was wonderful to meet them, to talk to them about the schools. So that is a tricky situation.

[05:35:29] It's also been a longstanding practice for the different various groups in the county. And just correct me if I'm wrong, I think we answered this question in committee. Version where staff recommended that we remove it that version with the red line strikeout Was not part of the version that went out for public feedback And so we haven't really put a fulsome version of this out for formal feedback solicitation And that's really my pause here is like I feel like I need to hear from people about this because this would be a big shift But I also feel like I would like to hear from more parents about how they're impacted by it as well as

[05:36:06] Building administrators, so is that correct that that did not go out for feedback with the strikeout? That's correct It changed in committee between it being an information item and an action item So when it went out for public feedback as all of our policies do It did not include some of these revisions that were made by staff and by committee members when it came back for action So I agree with everything you said okay the version as it sits in front of you did not receive public feedback as it sits tonight Thank you for those clarifications and I appreciate the dialogue.

[05:36:41] Thank you, Ms. Chernoff. And Ms. Allen, would you like to follow up on any points? Oh, I was just going to mention and kind of tagging on to what Dr. Bergen said. Like Ms. Chernoff shared, of course, for folks who are following the rules that we set, it can be a great experience and very positive.

[05:36:59] And the issue, of course, is that we have these bad actors who don't follow those rules, and they go into the schools and distribute materials or talk to parents as they're trying to meet their kid's teacher or talk to their principal, and that's where we run into problems.

[05:37:15] And so we've heard from many principals. We've heard from teachers and parents and things, and so we're just trying to find a solution that works for everybody. Thank you. Ms. Donahue, I saw your—or, pardon me. I'm so sorry. It's getting late. Chair Donahue, I saw your hand up a few minutes ago.

[05:37:34] Yes. Thank you very much, Madam Chair. I just wanted to say in partial response to Ms. Chernoff's comments, I did make this proposed change in the committee.

[05:37:55] immediately after we voted on it, I was already thinking there are additional edits to make in efforts to make it a more workable solution. I do not want to add any burden or stress to our staff or our families, but as has been pointed out, there are people who have said that allowing a limited, this kind of limited contact on non-election days, some people have argued,

[05:38:34] is a benefit to the community. And I was hoping to continue to work with staff to try and come up with a workable, a potentially workable outcome. This item being before the board tonight as an information item. I think if fellow board members are inclined to consider allowing limited distribution on non-election days, I do think there is more work to be done here. But if the

[05:39:12] majority feeling of my fellow board members would be that, no, we should not do that. We should adopt staff's original recommendation to prohibit such distribution of material on, except for on election days, where it would be permitted only on election days, then I think this policy is, and personally, I think this policy would then be in fine shape, ready to go.

[05:39:43] Although I hope that there may be a way to try and find a middle ground, but that may or may not be possible thank you thank you school board members are there any other questions miss Riccardi I also just want to put this out there being from Sterling there it is really difficult to get parents engaged in many ways just for a whole host of reasons back to school night is one of the very few opportunities to get a neat parents in the community and I do feel like it

[05:40:20] definitely limits anybody that's running for anything in that district in particular makes it really difficult I can't speak to the rest of the districts because I haven't been out canvassing in any of them but I think we've got to also keep that in mind too it's a great way for lots of people from different there people from the unions and all kinds of people out talking to voters and parents at those back-to-school nights I think I think that would be a real misstep for our most vulnerable communities to limit that access thank you. Any further questions? School board members, by show of thumbs up or thumbs down, would

[05:40:57] you like to send this back to LAMP? Oh, let's see. For continued work and perhaps some additional feedback. Okay. But in this case, Mr. Allen, we have the majority. I just want to confirm that that's appropriate the vote is 8-1 or the temperature check is 8-1 yes that's customary okay thank you so much this item will go back to legislative audit and policy committee

[05:41:35] we will continue on now with student behavior and accountability this is item 13.12 revisions to policy 8205 disciplinary authority and tonight will be presented by miss Carrie Thank You madam chair as we as I've said it at numerous other presentations of our policy from SBAC we have been working at cleaning up the policy getting the regulation consistent with state regs and state codes and this is another

[05:42:13] example of that I see miss Scanlon here if you'd like to say more about it yes Yes. Thank you very much. Um, the revisions to 8205, um, predominantly are for increased transparency. Um, I think that this will be a much more useful, um, policy to inform not only our families and our students, but also our school administrators. Um, the bulk of student

[05:42:50] discipline is applied after a student engages in misconduct that is directly related to school typically it occurs on school property at a school-sponsored activity etc this policy precisely defines what is meant by school policy so excuse me school property so that that can't be misunderstood or misconstrued. It also references where the definition of what a LCPS sponsored activity is, where that can be found. And then I think importantly,

[05:43:25] it sets forth the six specific occasions where a student can be disciplined at school for something that did not take place on school property or at a school sponsored activity those six occasions are very narrow they do not happen with regularity but in the interest of transparency we believed it was important to provide notice of that as well thank you

[05:44:03] school board members do we have any questions mr enough i'll make it quick um i in talking to staff with about this policy one of the things that just jumped out at me right away was lines starts on mid line five and six where it struck out each student has a responsibility to ensure that their behavior does not deny the right to others that right to others and one of the main things that I hear in schools and you know repeatedly in terms of behavior and discipline is that it becomes really tricky when the discipline isn't centralized to just that student but it starts to impact the education of the students around them so

[05:44:41] So I'm just, I know that those instances are detailed out in the bottom of what that would be specifically, and I'm grateful for that. I just feel like as sort of an intro paragraph to this policy, I would like to see that not struck out and kept as a placeholder for making sure that that is a standard that we adhere to.

[05:45:00] So I will probably be bringing that amendment, and I'm just making you aware that I feel like that should stay. Ms. Scanlon, did you want to speak to any reason why that shouldn't stay? So I just reworked, I think, those intro paragraphs and replaced that language with references to ensuring an environment that is safe and conducive to teaching and learning and with references to the need for students to be self-disciplined, become responsible

[05:45:38] citizens, and to discourage conduct that adversely impacts the health, safety, and well-being of others so it was certainly not my intent to dilute what the expectations are and in my view the expectations haven't been diluted but certainly I wouldn't object to you putting that phrase or sentence back in I appreciate that thank you any further questions all right given that amendments are on the table this item will come back for action

[05:46:16] at our next school board meeting, and we will move to item 13.13, our last information item of the evening, Student Behavior and Accountability Committee revisions to policy 8220, student disciplinary consequences, which will also be presented tonight by Ms. LaBelle. Thank you, Madam Chair. This kind of follows naturally after the policy that we just put out, the discipline authority and here is our reference to student disciplinary consequences and I

[05:46:51] think it's fairly specific it's it's certainly well structured it tells all the different things in increasing order if Miss Scanlon wants to say anything else thank you Miss LaBelle yes again the motivate

well there were a few motivations in revising this policy one again I have to come back to transparency and clarity as somebody who was new to the system myself two years ago I found

[05:47:28] that it I had to go through many policies and regulations to find the portions or the definitions I was looking for so again this is an effort to bring all sanctions into one place or to at least reference and define them in one place with necessary cross references so it is providing for our students our families and our staff the breadth of disciplinary sanctions that can be administered to students it also defines

[05:48:02] precisely what roles have the authority to impose certain sanctions because principals have certain authority the division superintendent and designee has somewhat different authority and of course the school board is the only authority that can expel a student in addition to that we have included certain definitions that i believe are important for example the definition of aggravating circumstances is printed as opposed to referenced aggravating circumstances are not easy to find when you're looking for them,

[05:48:39] so I felt that it was important to print those in the policy. And finally, and this extremely important, is we have included a provision that we are permitted to include by law, by code, but we currently have not included in any policy, and that is to provide notice of the authority to suspend a student for 10 days in conjunction with a recommendation for reassignment if a student has been charged with a specified criminal offense that implies intentional injury to another student in the same

[05:49:19] building. While the code provides for that, it also provides that we can invoke that authority only if our policy permits it. And currently our policy is silent to the issue. So I felt that was an important addition as well to provide for student safety thank you miss labelle and miss scanlon school board members are there any questions at this time seeing no questions is there any appetite to move this to consent okay this item will come back as an action item at the

[05:49:56] next school board meeting for further discussion i like the two items being paired together thank you so much we will now move on to the item we have on the agenda for discussion tonight this is item 14.01 the Ashburn and Dulles North elementary attendance zones tonight this item will be presented by dr. Rasheed thank you chair Chandler and thank you for putting this on the agenda thank you miss LaBelle and thank you mr. pepper for supporting me and bringing this on

[05:50:32] the agenda as well rezoning is never easy it's not an easy process all the families all the students the parents everything gets disrupted it's also very frustrating and to be honest at times it well I guess all the time it's it feels like it's very unfair and I mean I think I said this over and over again and I'm gonna say it again my district Little River District is the only district of all our districts here that gets rezoned the most okay especially in recent years so I mean I think we've heard from constituents saying there was also heartland a year before us and I think that

[05:51:09] there was one in Dulles which was in another district so it's it's quite a disruption but in Little River I feel like it's getting to the point where there's it's causing a lot of anxiety it's like basically saying when a family purchases a home it's like saying hey you know when you purchase this home here's this disclaimer you're going to get rezoned after like a year it's just it's just overwhelming sometimes I even feel like we're going to rename our our district Little River District to the rezoning district because it's just all the time and that's really really frustrating so as a school board representative Little River District I feel that it's important

[05:51:48] to diminish this anxiety bring stability bring a sense of community so in the adoptive plan 280 I feel like that was the least support received. I feel like there was a lot of opposition to it. And this is feedback that I received even before the vote on December 16th.

[05:52:07] So we're seeing the issue now evolve. We heard public comment. We all here have received all those emails. I personally have received lots of emails, lots of phone calls. So again, there is that sense of community and stability that we need to bring to the table.

[05:52:22] specifically I really want to mention the Willowsford community and the Brambleton community and they are suffering the most we have an awesome school Madison's Trust but again this is a great opportunity for their voices to be heard for their perspectives to be heard as well and I also think speaking of opportunity I think that now that we have some you know new school board members here on the dais I think that it's a great opportunity for these new school board members along with the current members to express their opinion, to have a better understanding, and to bring about this discussion. And like I said before, I want to

[05:53:01] halt all redistricting as much as possible. In fact, I would like to halt it completely at least till our residential developments get built out. So, you know, that's something that's really near and dear to me. And then also we have HS14 or our new high school that's being open as we speak. So that's being worked on. That's being worked on. So we're going to get more and more people that are going to get redistricted as well. So there have been other districts that have reached out to me. I do want to give them a shout out like Dominion Trail and every and a lot of

[05:53:35] other schools. But I, you know, I really wanted to stress that my district really gets really gets a lot of heat on that. And then so Madam Chair and fellow school board members, thank you for taking the time out for hearing my voice. I also am very grateful for all the people that came out to speak for public comment virtually and in person. But while this is a discussion matter, I think that I wanted to gauge from my board members if they're willing to revisit the December

[05:54:06] 16th vote. Thank you, Chair. Thank you, board members. It is 1020, and I just want to remind to everyone that we still have a closed session this evening, and it's anticipated that we will be in closed session for an hour and a half. That said, I appreciate that the community's here and would like to know if you have any further questions or comments on this issue. Mr. Pepper?

[05:54:39] Chair Chandler, I know you wanted to say Dr. Pepper, and that's okay. We all need a laugh at 1020 at night. I want to echo a lot of what Dr. Rashid has said.

[05:54:55] You know, I personally, and many of you know this, have seen me speak on this dais because I live in a school boundary that got rezoned last April. And I know the anxiety and I know the kind of disruption that rezoning brings to all communities.

[05:55:15] but it's also a fact of life growing up here in Loudoun County because we've been growing nonstop for the past 30 years. What I would like to say though is we have the opportunity now as a new board to do something extraordinary and to do something very special. Right now we've got two things going for us. One, we have HS14. When that is done, that is our last new school to be built in a very long time. Additionally, our enrollment has plateaued, although there are

[05:55:52] pockets that are still available for growth, and weirdly, yes, they're mostly in Little River. Let's just be very clear. We also have schools that do things like the school that my children are zoned to, where

after elementary school, they split, right? They go to a different middle school and a different high school than half of their peers, and so when you get to that transition point that sixth grade or even that ninth grade, perhaps the two most difficult years for students in education, they're now losing a good chunk of their built-in peer and friend group that they've

[05:56:26] made. We have the ability as a board to wait and say, you know what, we did a lot of really great practice with rezoning, a lot of really great practice playing with maps. And if you look at some of the maps, they look really fun, like gerrymandered electoral districts. We have a chance as a board to wait and stop not just this rezoning from Dulles North that happened in December right before the break, but even going back to April and saying, you know what, let's

[05:57:00] put a pause. Let's put a pause on all rezoning. Let's get high school 14 built and let's do it right. And I know Ms. Tate's probably going to dislike what I'm about to say, but let's start from scratch and do the county all at once. So our school zones don't look like dragons eating a Pac-Man and do it right from the start in a way that gives us the ability to be pyramidal and keep our kids together K-12 and in a way that you know makes the most sense for our community we have just a couple more years to see where those growth pockets really are so I'm going to put that out

[05:57:40] there I know we're not voting on anything tonight but this is something for your consideration it's something that can really change the way we do things in Loudoun County because a pyramidal system allows vertical collaboration between teachers in a pyramid. It allows students to stay with their peers. There's a lot of really wonderful benefits to all of this. So I'm going to put that out there as just a proposition and a thing to have said, because let's face it, this is unprecedented what is here right now. And I feel for the parents, but I also feel for those teachers, right? To lose 35 teachers in a building that have built those communities, that hurts.

[05:58:19] And so that's where I'm at, and I'm just going to just leave it at that. Thank you, Mr. Pepper. Any further? Mr. Svensson. Thanks, Madam Chair. I think I really appreciate the comments from the Madison's Trust community tonight.

[05:58:36] And I just want to say, because the discussion item was framed around Madison's Trust, I don't think the folks at Dominion Trail had the opportunity to speak to this issue. so I want to speak to my concerns and Dominion Trail communities concerns about plan 280 which passed in December. I think that we had good intentions in plan 280 to bring folks who in some of the staff plans were going to be going to Stewart Weller back to an elementary school in which they would feed into

[05:59:08] Farmwell station but I am concerned that by shifting folks from the DN 05.3 neighborhood from Dominion Trail to Ashburn Elementary we've merely moved a over capacity elementary school from Dominion Trail to Ashburn Elementary you know both schools are older elementary schools in our county have similar capacities and now if you look at the numbers we are at much higher much higher enrollment at Ashburn Elementary that is not going to serve

[05:59:42] the students there well and knowing that Dominion Trail is anticipated to not be served as a title one school come the 2026 2027 school year and by the way that this is you know December 2025 data this is based on December 2025 data we we don't anticipate that Dominion Trail will be served as a title one school in 2026 2027 the the capacity at Dominion Trail will increase and if you

[06:00:17] look at the numbers Dominion Trail to Ashburn with that status changed we can keep the students from DN 05.3 at Dominion Trail and the numbers will be roughly even between Ashburn Elementary and Dominion Trail and in that way we're actually utilizing Dominion Trail and Ashburn Elementary at a rate that makes sense and we're not shifting the problem to Ashburn Elementary from Dominion Trail. I understand that we want to have predictability in the school board's decisions. I understand that kindergarten enrollment is going to be beginning soon. I understand that a special permission will be beginning

[06:00:57] soon and that this board will have to make a decision quickly in order to not cause disruption for the upcoming school year but I also know that when there are issues that have been brought to our attention by the community we have an obligation to listen to them and to think through you know the the practical ways we can solve that problem and I would like to take the opportunity as the board to work on those and you know I don't want to be isolated just to one community, not just to Willsford and Brambleton Town Center, but I'd like to bring Ashburn Village

[06:01:32] to the conversation as well. Mrs. Griffiths? Thank you, Madam Chair. As everybody knows, I'm not for redistricting or anything like that, but by pushing back, I just had one question for miss Tate just to uh confirm or verify for me um if we were to push back um rezoning for two years i think that affects selden's landing correct um selden's needs those people

[06:02:06] need to go back to their school um they were right across the street and they were uh they were rezoned to Stewart Weller so i just want to make sure that they're not i mean that would mean everybody if you pushed back rezoning for two years is that right can you just clarify that for me i'm uncertain as to what direction the board is indicating tonight if it's just to look at certain planning zones or the whole adopted attendance zone for the 16th if it's the entire

[06:02:40] attendance zone process then that would involve selden's landing as well as i understand it yes ma'am. I would say certain plans would be better to push back, not all of them. Thank you. Yes, Mr. Svensson. I just wanted to say that I agree with what Mrs. Griffiths just said. I would focus on the specific planning zones and not the entire plan because, you know, my neighborhood was rezoned and we don't mind. We're used to going to either Mill Run or Hillside in Broadlands and that's okay but I know there are particular communities that this is

[06:03:19] hitting harder and if you look at the the data and we have we have a lot of data experts here in Loudoun County at least now if you look at it some of the decisions I think could be looked at again and we can do this in a way that makes sense and keeps communities together okay so from a next steps perspective I'd like to ask dr. Rashid to repose her question because she has presented the board with a question thank you chair Chandler I my question I

[06:03:55] guess it's more I guess like more of a topic is I want to revisit the December 16th vote can we read revisit the December 16th vote I guess that's the question okay so a discussion item as a next step becomes an action item so please show by thumbs up or thumbs down if you would like to see this discussion item come back on the agenda for the next school board meeting and I would propose that people be ready with any amendments so that we have plenty of time to consider and offer the community as much information as they need to

[06:04:35] understand what's happening. Chair Chandler would this be on the 28th or like at the next school board meeting which is Wednesday the 28th. Okay so would you like Ms. Chernoff? I have a

question for staff before we move forward with that next step um because i think mr spenson sort of touched on it but it's my understanding that we have some upcoming dates uh that are key for special permission registration staffing fifth grade rollover kindergarten registration all happening in the next few weeks here based off

[06:05:12] the decision that was already made in that manner so that we could be prepared for those things going forward. So I would just really appreciate some clarity around timeline here and the impact that this will have not only on our staff at the division level but also at the school level and how this impacts us more than just revisiting a decision and reversing something potentially which is something that we have not done in past practice as a board. So if there could be some voices that could chime into that so we can understand the impact of a decision

[06:05:49] of pushing this two weeks to action. Thank you Mrs. Chernoff for your question. I'm going to take the aspect of special permission and then my other colleagues will be jumping in on some of those other timelines that you mentioned. The board made a decision on December 16th to move forward with a reduction in capacity to 85%. You also voted that same night on boundaries and

[06:06:16] And so staff have done the work in DDI as well as in planning and in student services to make sure students have rolled over based on those boundary changes so that we could calculate base capacity for schools to get the portal ready, which is slated to open on Tuesday, January 20th.

[06:06:36] So if you delay a vote or revisit the topic of boundary changes, we will have to delay the opening of the special permission portal because that could have far-reaching consequences. So now we have schools saying that we're at 85% capacity, but if you guys change boundaries again, it's possible that they could have capacity.

[06:06:59] So we will have to delay that process based on your decision tonight. and should that be the will of the board, then that is what staff will do. We will work with DCE as well as planning to adjust the communications to our parents and our staff members that wish to access this process about the delay.

[06:07:20] And I do remind you that we kept the end date of the special permission process is April 30th. So you'd be shortening the window that staff and families would have to access that process. Thank you. Mrs. Richardson.

[06:07:36] Oh, yes, please, Ms. Boland. I can speak to staffing timelines. So when the board took action at the December meeting, our team did extend the voluntary, round one of the voluntary transfer process for individuals who felt they would be potentially set up to be involuntarily transferred based on seniority to essentially take their career into their own hands and make a decision on wanting to voluntarily submit that transfer.

[06:08:17] That process ended on January 9th. From that date, we offer a minimum based on policy and regulation of 30 days for principals to access that voluntary transfer process list before we begin looking at involuntary placements.

[06:08:39] Now, it's really important that we have the list of involuntary transfer placements in coordination with not only the budget, but any other vacancies that will become available because those are already LCPS employees. And so we will want to make sure that they have placements, they have homes.

[06:08:58] And we often use those timelines to dictate when we will allow principals to start posting jobs externally and bringing in external candidates.

[06:09:15] So any type of change to this process could delay a principal's ability to start posting jobs. And that will most likely impact more of our high needs Title I schools because those are the schools that we try to post sooner.

[06:09:34] Sure enough. Thank you. I appreciate that. I just want to address a couple of things. I know, I mean, it was my plan, so I'm going to own it. And I hear you and I understand where you're coming from.

[06:09:51] I see the tears and all the things. And I was a teacher. I know what it's like to be in these situations. I also want to address the fact that this, for me personally, did follow extensive research, meetings with stakeholders, meetings with communities, meetings with staff, understanding of transportation, understanding of staffing, understanding of special permission.

[06:10:16] I mean, it's a far reaching decision. And I really, I am concerned that if we bump this two weeks, that we are now further jeopardizing other people that we're maybe not thinking about. and that domino effect. And so I don't think it's really gonna surprise anybody that I stand by my original vote.

[06:10:37] And I am concerned also about a precedent that we could be setting moving forward to make these decisions that are tough but were made by a majority vote of the board and then reversing them and going back. And I think that that can be confusing for staff.

[06:10:53] I think it can be confusing for a school board. And I understand, I mean, Leesburg is not as often rezoned as Little River so I hear you Dr. Rasheed. I think it is troubling. I will say from my point of view some of the decisions I was making were for that bigger picture so that if we made those changes down the road we wouldn't have to revisit Madison's Trust Elementary or maybe other buildings. So that's where I'm coming from so you asked our opinion if we wanted to revisit I am going to say no for various larger contextual bigger picture vision type of things that I'm looking at and were part of my decision

[06:11:30] but I I hope that we can be very clear about what we're doing moving forward because I think the public deserve to know what that is as well as staff so that they can make the changes that they need to thank you thank you mr. pepper quick question for miss Bolin so if a staff member has entered the voluntary the transfer portal because they felt they were going to be de-staffed due to these decisions is there a way for them to rescind their entrance into that portal so they wouldn't

[06:12:08] necessarily need to rescind um the the fact that uh principals the access to that portal or pool of individuals who submitted voluntary transfers is now open to principals to set up interviews and make offers no offers have been made they would just decline to interview they could absolutely work with the team to be removed from the pool but they would just decline an interview thank you

[06:12:43] miss Bolin any further questions or comments all right by show of thumbs up would you like this item to come back at the next school board meeting we'll see you in January that's about five to four

[06:13:12] Thank you to the audience for your patience tonight and we are going to continue on with our meeting, so thank you.

[06:13:28] Sorry. Okay. We have a proposal in terms of managing the time that we need to spend in closed session and I would like to get a sense from the board if we could have a quorum to continue our closed session on Thursday night.

[06:13:46] We would discuss one item tonight and move two to Thursday. Okay. Thank you so much. So we'll wait just a minute to let the room clear.

[06:14:59] Great. Thank you so much, everyone, for your patience, as we have definitely had many trials and tribulations today. With that, Vice Chair Donahue, do you have a motion? Yes, thank you. Yes, thank you, Madam Chair. Sorry.

[06:15:33] I am having a slight computer glitch. I do have a motion. Vice Chair Donahue, in the interest of time, I'm going to ask Ms. Chernoff to read the motion.

[06:15:53] Okay. Thank you. Thank you, Madam Chair. I move that the Loudoun County School Board recesses public meeting and enter into a closed meeting pursuant to 2.2 - 3 7 1 2 of the code of Virginia for the following purposes consultation with legal counsel and briefings by staff member or consultations pertaining to actual or probable litigation where such consultation or briefing and open meeting would adversely affect the negotiating or litigating posture of the public body as authorized by the section 2.2 - 3 7 1 1 a 7 of the code of Virginia and

[06:16:32] Consultation with legal counsel employed or retained by a public body regarding a specific legal matter requiring the provision of legal advice by such counsel as Authorized by section 2.2 - 3 7 1 1 8 of the code of Virginia Mr. Chernoff has made a motion. Do I have a second second? Oh, thank you. Miss Riccardi It has been properly moved and seconded that the Loudoun County School Board go into closed session Is there any discussion seeing none clerk, please open the vote school board members?

[06:17:07] please record your vote. Ms. Donahue, please state your vote. Yes.

[06:17:27] Clerk, please close and display the vote. The motion passes unanimously with all nine school board members voting yes. The board is now

[06:17:42] in closed session. Yeah. Yeah.

[06:41:15] Motion to adjourn. All right. We are now coming out of closed session.

[06:41:36] Ms. Chernoff, do you have a motion? Yes, I do. Thank you, Madam Chair. I move that the closed meeting be adjourned and that the Loudoun County School Board reconvene its public meeting and that the minutes of the public meeting reflect that no formal action was taken in the closed meeting. Thank you. Ms. Chernoff has made a motion. Do I have a second? Second. I'm sorry, Mr. Pepper?

[06:41:56] Second. Thank you. I just wanted to confirm that I caught that. Thank you. I have a second by Mr. Pepper. It has been properly moved and seconded that the Loudoun County School Board adjourn the closed session. Is there any discussion? Clerk, please open the vote. Board members, please record your vote. Please close and display the vote. The motion passes with Ms. Riccardi, Mr. Svensson,

[06:42:32] Ms. Chernoff, Chair Chandler, Mrs. Griffiths, Mr. Pepper, Dr. Rasheed, Ms. LaBelle voting yes, and Vice Chair Donohue absent for the vote. Now, Ms. Chernoff, do you have a motion? I do. I move that the following resolution certifying the closed meeting be adopted and reflected in the minutes of this public meeting. Whereas the Loudoun County School Board has convened a closed meeting on this date pursuant to the affirmative recorded vote and in accordance with the provisions of the Virginia Freedom of Information Act and whereas 2.2-3712D of the Code of Virginia

[06:43:09] requires a certification by the school board and that such closed meeting was conducted in conformity with the Virginia law. Now therefore be it resolved that the Loudoun County School Board

hereby certifies that to the best of each member's knowledge One, only public business matters lawfully exempt from open meeting requirements by Virginia law were discussed in the closed meeting to which the certification applies.

[06:43:28] And two, only such public business matters as were identified in the motion conveying the closed meeting were heard, discussed, or considered by the Loudoun County School Board. Thank you. Ms. Chernoff has made a motion. Do I have a second? Thank you, Ms. LaBelle. I have a second by Ms. LaBelle.

[06:43:47] It has been properly moved and seconded that the Loudoun County School Board certify the closed meeting. Is there any discussion? Clerk, please open the vote. Board members, please record your vote. Clerk, please close and display the vote.

[06:44:07] The motion passes with eight members voting yes, including Ms. Riccardi, Mr. Svensson, Ms. Chernoff, Chair Chandler, Mrs. Griffiths, Mr. Pepper, Dr. Rasheed, and Ms. LaBelle, with Vice Chair Donahue absent for the vote.

[06:44:26] there's no motion required for the closed meeting um our next item is um board member comments and committee reports could you please show me by uh thumbs up if you would like to make a comment tonight oh wait oh oh you said my thumbs up no okay sorry it's very late i know um thank you so much um we will not have board member comments and committee reports tonight um is there any new business all right the january 13th 2026 school board meeting is adjourned just a reminder that

[06:45:05] we'll be back here on thursday january 15th at 4 30 for the school board budget work session thank you so much for your hard work tonight and please drive home safely



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